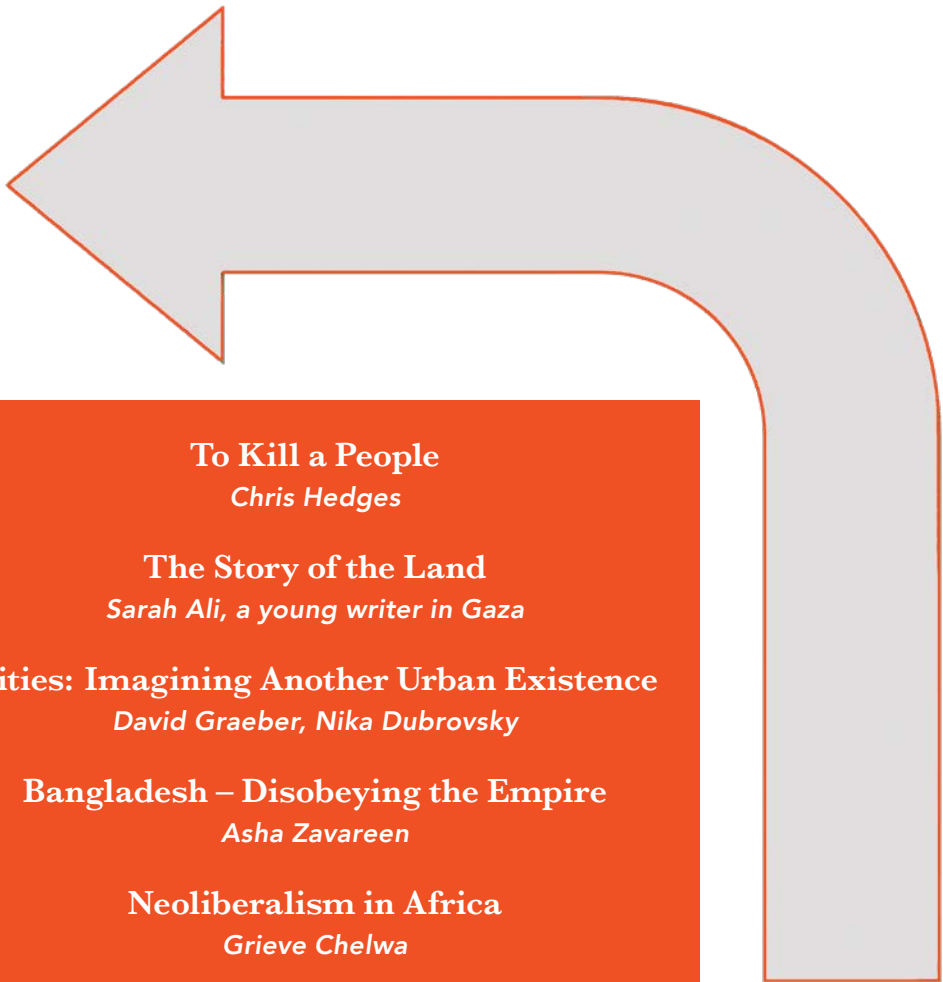


Left Turn

A Quarterly Journal of Critical Voices



To Kill a People

Chris Hedges

The Story of the Land

Sarah Ali, a young writer in Gaza

Cities: Imagining Another Urban Existence

David Graeber, Nika Dubrovsky

Bangladesh – Disobeying the Empire

Asha Zavareen

Neoliberalism in Africa

Grieve Chelwa

I Am You

Poem by Refaat Alareer

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Notes from the Editors

Why Trump? It Was About Saying “Fuck You” To the Establishment

I have no blindingly insightful analysis to offer about Trump’s victory over Kamala Harris, the Democratic Party, and the establishment portion of the Republican Party, but here’s my tentative take: The presidential election wasn’t a vote for fascism or even a vote for Trump. I sense that a sizable number of voters were saying, “I don’t like Trump, and I know my life won’t be better under him — but I’m voting for him or not voting at all.”

White folks in rural Iowa, Black voters in Detroit, and Puerto Ricans in nearby Allentown found an opportunity, in the words of Professor Keeanga-Yamahatta Taylor, to “give the finger, to thumb your nose at the status quo...” Even NYTimes columnist David Brooks surprised me with his op-ed “Voters to Elite: Do You See Me Now?” In a PBS interview, Brooks acknowledged that race and gender had receded in salience as class was on the rise.

It’s hard to say what part foreign policy played in the election, but a pollster cited by Gabriel Winant in *Dissent*, found that younger voters believe that America is “a dying empire led by bad people.” We do know that if Harris had been elected, we’d simply have a female face fronting the US role in genocide. This would not be unlike the female Golda “Palestinians Are Cockroaches” Meir leading the colonial settler state of Israel. And Harris would have continued the conflict in Ukraine, the U.S. proxy war provoked against Russia that could have been avoided. As of mid-September 2024, it’s estimated that one million people have been killed or wounded in this war. This affirms what Mike Parenti once argued that what matters is not what’s between the loins but between the ears.

To be sure, the vote was not transactional, but it was evidence that the poor and working class have simply stopped believing the mainstream media lies and have only contempt for politicians who hector and patronize them, calling them “deplorables” and “garbage.” This disdain extends to the institutions of government that have lost their legitimacy. For Blacks, it includes the Black misleadership class like the condescending Obamas and the sell-outs in Congress like Clyburn and Jeffries who “go along to get

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2025: Amid the Darkness, Glimmers of Light

RICHARD FALK

[Prefatory Note: This attempt to cast a critical gaze at the year ahead was published as an opinion piece by Anadolu News Agency in Turkey. It is republished here without modification.]

Rarely has the crystal ball used to divine the near future seemed so clouded by uncertainties. The year 2024 was dominated by disappointments, disturbing surprises, and continuing devastation in Ukraine and Gaza. It was also a year that underscored the inability of the UN to stop the most transparent genocide ever in Gaza, a senseless war in Ukraine, and mass slaughter in Sudan.

Is 2024 a turning point?

There were a variety of multilateral efforts in 2024 to escape from US international dominance after the Cold War. This dominance had fueled a global politics of resentment and a search for an alternative world order that is law-governed and not subject to the geopolitical maneuvers of the five winners of World War II. These powers were granted unrestricted veto rights in the UN Security Council under the UN Charter, which has long paralyzed efforts to ensure compliance with international law. This produces a deep contradiction in the way the world is organized, allowing the most powerful and dangerous countries, all five being nuclear-armed states, to be legally free of any obligation to respect international law.

The question in many thoughtful minds is whether these developments in the prior year will continue in the year ahead. One near certain development is the rightward turn of internal politics in the West, given a dramatic twist by the prospects of radical change associated with the second coming of Donald Trump as US president. Trump has already appointed highly controversial political figures to his Cabinet, with the expectation of implementing an ultra-right domestic agenda. However, what is his approach to foreign policy? As well, the leading governments of Europe, including Germany, France, and Italy, all exhibit signs of leaning further toward authoritarianism.

Crisis areas in the world

There are some hopeful signs. Trump seems likely to push for a negotiated peace in Ukraine and bring to a close US President Joe Biden's "geopolitical war," involving fighting Moscow by supplying and funding Kyiv with ever more provocative weaponry while turning his back on diplomacy and urging NATO to join in the fight with Russia to the last Ukrainian. Such a posture raised risks of a confrontation with Russia that could also result in catastrophic nuclear warfare. Trump wants to cut spending on distant and expensive foreign adventures with no genuine

American security interest and stand before the world as a peacemaker. Ukraine was a war that never should have been, as a diplomatic compromise between Russia and Ukraine was from its inception in the interest of Ukraine and world peace, as well as being attainable by responsible statecraft.

In contrast to Ukraine, the context of Israel/Palestine is far bleaker. There is every indication that Trump intends to outdo Biden by being an even more unconditional ally of Israel, fully supportive of the Netanyahu-led project entailing the establishment of Greater Israel. This is a plan to erase the Palestinian challenge through the annexation of the West Bank, parts of Gaza, and to support Israel in extending its "buffer zones" in Syria and Lebanon. The plan also includes intensified efforts to destroy Iran's nuclear program and promote regime change in Tehran by force. The rightward turn of major governments in the West is likely to repress civil society opposition to the continuation of Israeli genocide and expansionism.

Militarism versus symbolic victories: The calculus of legitimacy wars

The efforts by countries in the Global South to have recourse to the International Court of Justice (ICJ) and International Criminal Court (ICC) are a notable expression on the part of non-Western states to invoke international law to serve the causes of peace with justice. And the ICJ has responded in an encouraging professional manner, ruling in favor of provisional measures in response to South Africa's submission and issuing a separate opinion invalidating Israel's continuing occupation of Gaza, the West Bank, and East Jerusalem in an authoritative near-unanimous exposition of applicable international law. Of course, it is expected that Israel will defy these developments, as it has consistently done in the face of adverse rulings by international tribunals. Nevertheless, such rulings sympathetic with Palestinian grievances are symbolically important, delegitimizing Israel and mobilizing civil society activism that gives rise to global solidarity initiatives of a Boycott, Divestment, and Sanctions (BDS) variety.

The fate of the arrest warrants issued by the ICC, ordering the arrest and transfer to The Hague for prosecution of Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and former Defense Minister Yoav Gallant after a long delay is highly uncertain. Israel has mounted a legal challenge, and its government has made clear that the arrest warrants for the Israeli leaders are antisemitic outrages, and any implementation would be denounced and disrupted no matter what the ICC might decide. As with the ICJ genocide and occupation cases, the mere issuance of arrest warrants by the ICC was a significant symbolic Palestinian victory in the Legitimacy War, which may yet surprise the world in 2025 or shortly thereafter, by its overall impact on the viability of the Israeli state as now operative. It should be appreciated that the anti-colonial wars of the past 50 years were won by the weaker side militarily that managed to prevail on the symbolic battlefields of the Legitimacy War, which gives decisive weight to law, morality, and perseverance of a repressed people. The establishment of the civil society Gaza Tribunal in November of 2024 is a further legitimizing development in the Palestinian struggle for basic rights that seeks to activate global solidarity initiatives that shifted the balance in the global movement against South African apartheid, and

before that of the global anti-war movement that nullified US military superiority in the Vietnam War.

The rise of multipolarity in 2025?

At the same time, global society is experiencing a surge of multilateral initiatives. Strengthening the impulse to create autonomous multipolar networks of the sort modeled by the BRICS, and especially to mount challenges to dollarization of trade and finance, which, to the extent successful, will produce a backlash in the form of high tariffs and the economic menace of a trade war, aggravated by an increase in the tendency to replace workers with digitally sophisticated substitutes for human labor to promote profitability and efficiency.

Above all, 2025 will witness growing tensions between the unified governance of global security by continued US hegemony and a resurgent challenge mounted by the Global South in the ongoing Legitimacy War with the West.

Richard Falk is a leading international law professor emeritus at Princeton University, prominent activist, UN Special Rapporteur for Occupied Palestine (2008–2014), and pioneer thinker dedicated to peace and justice. He has been nominated annually since 2009 for the Nobel Peace Prize. He is a prolific author, including the upcoming Ukraine in the Shadow of Geopolitics, and most recently, Protecting Human Rights in Occupied Palestine.

To Kill a People

CHRIS HEDGES

Extinction works. At first. This is the terrible lesson of history. If Israel is not stopped—and no outside power appears willing to halt the genocide in Gaza or the destruction of Lebanon—it will achieve its goals of depopulating and annexing northern Gaza. It will turn southern Gaza into a charnel house where Palestinians are [burned alive](#), decimated by bombs, and die from [starvation](#) and infectious diseases, until they are driven out. It will achieve its goal of destroying Lebanon—2,400 people have been [killed](#) and over 1.2 million Lebanese have been displaced—in an attempt to turn it into a failed state. It is already turning its genocidal fury on the West Bank. And, it may soon realize its long-cherished dream of forcing the United States into war with Iran. Israeli leaders are publicly salivating over proposals to assassinate Iranian leader Ayatollah Ali Hosseini Khamenei and carry out airstrikes on Iran's nuclear installations and oil facilities.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and his cabinet, like those driving Middle East policy in the White House—[Antony Blinken](#), raised in a staunch Zionist family, [Brett McGurk](#), [Amos Hochstein](#), who was born in Israel and served in the Israeli military, and Jake Sullivan—are [true believers](#) in the doctrine that violence can mold the world to fit their demented vision. That this doctrine has been a spectacular failure in Israel's occupied territories and did not work in Afghanistan, Iraq, Syria, and Libya, and a generation earlier in Vietnam, does not deter them. This time, they assure us, it will succeed.

In the short term, they are right. This is not good news for Palestinians or the Lebanese. The U.S. and Israel will continue to use their arsenal of industrial weapons to kill huge numbers of people and turn cities into rubble. But in the long term, this indiscriminate violence sows dragon's teeth. It creates adversaries that, sometimes a generation later, outdo in savagery—we call it terrorism—what was done to those slain in the previous generation.

Hate and lust for vengeance, as I learned covering the war in the former Yugoslavia, are passed down like a poisonous elixir from one generation to the next. Our disastrous interventions in Afghanistan, Iraq, Syria, Libya, and Yemen, along with Israel's invasion of Lebanon in 1982, which [created](#) Hezbollah, should have taught us this.

But this is a lesson that is never learned.

How could the Bush administration imagine it would be greeted as liberators in Iraq when the U.S. had spent over a decade imposing sanctions that resulted in severe shortages of food and medicine, [causing](#) the deaths of at least one million Iraqis, including 500,000 children?

Israel's occupation of Palestine and its saturation bombing of Lebanon in 1982, were the [catalyst](#) for Osama bin Laden's attack on the Twin Towers in New York City in 2001, along with U.S. support for attacks on Muslims in Somalia, Chechnya,

Kashmir, and the South of the Philippines, U.S. military assistance to Israel and the sanctions on Iraq.

I see nothing to halt Israel, especially since the Israel lobby has bought and paid for Congress and the two ruling parties and cowed the media and universities. There is money to be made in war. A lot of it. And the influence of the war industry, buttressed by hundreds of millions of dollars spent on political campaigns by the [Zionists](#), will be a formidable barrier to peace, not to mention sanity.

Israel has been poisoned by the psychosis of permanent war. It has been morally bankrupted by the sanctification of victimhood, which it uses to justify an occupation that is even more savage than that of apartheid South Africa. Its ‘democracy’—which was always exclusively for Jews—has been hijacked by extremists who are pushing the country towards fascism. Human rights campaigners, [intellectuals](#), and [journalists](#)—[Israeli](#) and [Palestinian](#)—are subject to constant state surveillance, arbitrary arrests, and government-run smear campaigns. Its educational system, starting in primary school, is an [indoctrination machine](#) for the military. The greed and corruption of its venal political and economic elite have created vast [income disparities](#), a mirror of the decay within America’s democracy, along with a culture of anti-Arab and anti-Black racism.

By the time Israel achieves its decimation of Gaza—Israel is [talking about](#) months more of warfare—its facade of civility, its supposed vaunted respect for the rule of law and democracy, its mythical story of the courageous Israeli military and miraculous birth of the Jewish nation—which it successfully sold to its western audiences—will lie in ash heaps. Israel’s social capital will be spent. It will be revealed as the ugly, repressive, hate-filled [apartheid](#) regime it always has been, alienating [younger](#) generations of American Jews. Its patron, the United States, as new generations come into power, will distance itself from Israel. Its popular support will come from reactionary Zionists and America’s Christianized [fascists](#) who see Israel’s domination of ancient Biblical land as a harbinger of the Second Coming and in its subjugation of Arabs a kindred racism and celebration of white supremacy.

Israel will become synonymous with its victims the way Turks are synonymous with the Armenians, Germans are with the Namibians and later the Jews, and Serbs are with the Bosniaks. Israel’s cultural, artistic, journalistic, and intellectual life will atrophy. Israel will be a stagnant nation where the religious fanatics, bigots, and Jewish extremists who have [seized power](#) will dominate public discourse. It will join the club of the globe’s most despotic regimes.

Despotisms can exist long after their past due date. But they are terminal.

Nations need more than force to survive. They need a mystique. This mystique provides purpose, civility, and even nobility to inspire citizens to sacrifice for the nation. The mystique offers hope for the future. It provides meaning. It provides national identity. When mystiques implode, when they are exposed as lies, a central foundation of state power collapses.

All Israel has left is escalating savagery, including [torture](#) and [lethal violence](#) against unarmed civilians, which accelerates the decline. The Israeli military has carried out 93 massacres in Gaza in the last year. This wholesale violence works in the short term, as it did in the war waged by the French in Algeria, the Dirty War

waged by Argentina’s military dictatorship, the British occupation of India, Egypt, Kenya, and Northern Ireland, and the American occupations of Vietnam, Iraq, and Afghanistan. But in the long term, it is suicidal.

The [genocide](#) in Gaza has turned Hamas’ resistance fighters into [heroes](#) in the [Global South](#). Israel has killed hundreds of Palestinian leaders, including Yahya Sinwar. It assassinated Dr. Abdel Aziz al-Rantisi, one of the founders of Hamas, who I knew, and Khalil al-Wazir, known as Abu Jihad, who founded the PLO with Yasser Arafat, who I also knew. But the daily humiliation, forced impoverishment, indiscriminate violence, long prison terms, and torture are fertile training grounds for resistance leaders. There is no shortage of radicalized Palestinians who can take Sinwar’s place. The long struggle for freedom by Palestinians has made this point over and over and over.

Run, the Israelis demand of the Palestinians in Gaza; run for your lives. Run from Rafah the way you ran from Gaza City, the way you ran from Jabalia, the way you ran from Deir al-Balah, the way you ran from Beit Hanoun, the way you ran from Bani Suheila, the way you ran from Khan Yunis. Run, or we will kill you. We will drop [GBU-39](#) bombs on your tent encampments and set them ablaze. We will spray you with bullets from our machine-gun-equipped drones. We will pound you with artillery and tank shells. We will shoot you down with snipers. We will decimate your tents, your refugee camps, your cities and towns, your homes, your schools, your hospitals, and your water purification plants. We will rain death from the sky.

Run for your lives. Again and again and again. Pack up the few belongings you have left. Blankets. A couple of pots. Some clothes. We don’t care how exhausted you are, how hungry you are, how terrified you are, how sick you are, how old, or how young you are. Run. Run. Run. And when you run in terror to one part of Gaza, we will make you turn around and run to another. Trapped in a labyrinth of death. Back and forth. Up and down. Side to side. Seven. Eight. Nine. Ten times. We toy with you like mice in a trap. Then we deport you, so you can never return. Or we kill you.

Let the world denounce our genocide. What do we care? The [billions](#) in military aid flow unchecked from our American ally. The fighter jets. The artillery shells. The tanks. The bombs. An endless supply. We kill children by the thousands. We kill women and the elderly by the thousands. The sick and injured, without medicine and hospitals, die. We poison the water. We cut off the food. We make you starve. We created this hell. We are the masters. Law. Duty. A code of conduct. They do not exist for us.

But first, we toy with you. We humiliate you. We terrorize you. We revel in your fear. We are amused by your pathetic attempts to survive. You are not human. You are creatures. Untermensch. We feed our lust for domination. Look at our posts on social media. They have gone viral. One shows soldiers grinning in a Palestinian home with the owners tied up and blindfolded in the background. We [loot](#). Rugs. Cosmetics. Motorbikes. Jewelry. Watches. Cash. Gold. Antiquities. We mock your misery. We cheer for your death. We celebrate our religion, our nation, our identity, and our superiority, by negating and erasing yours.

Depravity is moral. Atrocity is heroism. Genocide is redemption.

This is the game of terror played by Israel in Gaza. It was the game played during the Dirty War in Argentina, which I covered as a reporter when the military junta “disappeared” 30,000 of its own citizens. The “disappeared” were subjected to torture—who cannot call what is happening to Palestinians in Gaza torture?—and humiliated before they were murdered. It was the game played in the clandestine torture centers and prisons I reported on in El Salvador and Iraq. It is what I saw in the Serbian concentration camps in Bosnia.

Israeli journalist Yinon Magal on the show “Hapatriotim” on Israel’s Channel 14, [joked](#) that Joe Biden’s red line was the killing of 30,000 Palestinians. The singer Kobi Peretz asked if that was the number of dead for a day. The audience erupted in applause and laughter.

We know Israel’s intent. Annihilate the Palestinians the same way the United States annihilated Native Americans, the Australians annihilated the First Nations peoples, the Germans annihilated the Herero in Namibia, the Turks annihilated Armenians and the Nazis annihilated the Jews. The specifics are different. The goal is the same. Erasure.

We cannot plead ignorance.

But it is easier to pretend. Pretend Israel will allow humanitarian aid. Pretend there will be a permanent ceasefire. Pretend Palestinians will return to their destroyed homes in Gaza. Pretend Gaza will be rebuilt—the hospitals, the universities, the mosques, the housing. Pretend the Palestinian Authority will administer Gaza. Pretend there will be a [two-state solution](#). Pretend there is no genocide.

The vaunted democratic values, morality, and respect for human rights claimed by Israel and the United States have always been a lie. The real credo is this: we have everything, and if you try and take it away from us, we will kill you. People of color, especially when they are poor and vulnerable, do not count. The hopes, dreams, dignity, and aspirations for freedom of those outside the empire are worthless. Global domination will be sustained through [racialized violence](#).

This lie—that the American empire is predicated on democracy and liberty—is one the Palestinians, and those in the Global South, as well as Native Americans and Black and Brown Americans, not to mention those who live in the Middle East, have known for decades. But it is a lie that still has currency in the United States and Israel, a lie used to justify the unjustifiable.

We do not halt Israel’s genocide because we, as Americans, are Israel, infected with the same white supremacy, and intoxicated by our domination of the globe’s wealth and the power to obliterate others with our advanced weaponry.

The U.S. occupation forces in Iraq and Afghanistan, replicating what they did in Vietnam, deliberately maimed, abused, beat, tortured, raped, wounded, and killed hundreds of thousands of unarmed civilians, including children.

“After the war,” Nick Turse writes, “most scholars wrote off the accounts of widespread war crimes that recur throughout Vietnamese revolutionary publications and American antiwar literature as merely so much propaganda. Few academic historians even thought to cite such sources, and almost none did so extensively. Meanwhile, [My Lai](#) came to stand for—and thus blot out—all other American atrocities. Vietnam War bookshelves are now filled with big-picture histories, sober studies of

diplomacy and military tactics, and combat memoirs told from the soldiers’ perspective. Buried in forgotten U.S. government archives, locked away in the memories of atrocity survivors, the real American war in Vietnam has all but vanished from public consciousness.”

Historical amnesia is a vital part of extermination campaigns once they end, at least for the victors. But for the victims, the memory of genocide, along with a yearning for retribution, is a sacred calling. The vanquished reappear in ways the genocidal killers cannot predict, fueling new conflicts and new animosities. The physical eradication of all Palestinians, the only way genocide works, is an impossibility, given that six million Palestinians alone live in the diaspora. Over five million live in Gaza and the West Bank.

Israel’s genocide has enraged the 1.9 billion Muslims worldwide, as well as most of the Global South. It has discredited and weakened the corrupt and fragile regimes of the dictatorships and monarchies in the Arab world, home to 456 million Muslims, who collaborate with the U.S. and Israel. It has fueled the ranks of the Palestinian resistance.

What is happening in Gaza is not unprecedented. Indonesia’s military, backed by the U.S., carried out a [year-long campaign](#) in 1965 to exterminate those accused of being communist leaders, functionaries, party members, and sympathizers. The bloodbath—much of it carried out by rogue death squads and paramilitary gangs—decimated the labor union movement along with the intellectual and artistic class, opposition parties, university student leaders, journalists, and ethnic Chinese. A million people were slaughtered. Many of the bodies were dumped into rivers, hastily buried, or left to rot on roadsides.

This campaign of mass murder is today mythologized in Indonesia, as it will be in Israel. It is portrayed as an epic battle against the forces of evil, just as Israel equates the Palestinians with Nazis.

The killers in the Indonesian war against “communism” are cheered at political rallies. They are lionized for saving the country. They are interviewed on television about their “heroic” battles. The three-million-strong Pancasila Youth—Indonesia’s equivalent of the “Brownshirts” or the Hitler Youth—in 1965, joined in the genocidal mayhem and are held up as the pillars of the nation.

We mythologize our genocide of Native Americans, romanticizing our killers, gunmen, outlaws, militias, and cavalry units. We, like Israel, fetishize the military.

Industrial slaughter—what the sociologist James William Gibson calls “technowar”—defines Israel’s assault on Gaza and Lebanon. Technowar is centered on the concept of “overkill.” Overkill, with its intentionally large numbers of civilian casualties, is justified as an effective form of deterrence. It is what Israel cynically calls “mowing the lawn.”

The incursion on Oct. 7 into Israel by Hamas and other resistance groups, which left 1,154 Israelis, tourists, and migrant workers dead and saw about 240 people taken hostage, gave Israel the pretext for what it has long craved—the total erasure of Palestinians.

Israel has [damaged or destroyed](#) Gaza’s universities, all of which are now closed, and 60 percent of other educational facilities, including 13 libraries. It has also [destroyed](#) at least 195 heritage sites, including 208 mosques, churches, and Gaza’s

Central Archives, which [held](#) 150 years of historical records and documents. Israel's warplanes, missiles, drones, tanks, artillery shells, and naval guns daily pulverize Gaza—which is only 20 miles long and five miles wide—in a scorched earth campaign unlike anything seen since the war in Vietnam. It has dropped 25,000 tons of explosives—equivalent to two nuclear bombs—on Gaza, many targets selected by Artificial Intelligence. It drops unguided munitions (“dumb bombs”) and 2,000-pound “bunker buster” bombs on refugee camps and densely packed urban centers as well as the so-called “safe zones”—42 percent of Palestinians killed have been in these “safe zones” where they were instructed by Israel to flee. Over 1.9 million Palestinians have been displaced from their homes, forced to find refuge in overcrowded UNRWA shelters, hospital corridors, courtyards, schools, tents, or the open air in south Gaza, often living next to fetid pools of raw sewage.

The Israeli blockade of northern Gaza has left [over](#) 400,000 Palestinians enduring [a starvation](#) siege and constant [airstrikes](#) in an attempt to depopulate the north. Israeli forces have killed 1,250 Palestinians in the assault, launched on October 5, a medical source told Al Jazeera. Reports from northern Gaza are difficult to obtain as internet and phone services have been cut, and the few journalists on the ground [continue to be killed](#). Civil defense units say they have been [barred](#) by Israeli forces from reaching the sites of strikes, and their crews have been [attacked](#).

Israel has ordered Palestinians to flee to designated “safe zones,” but once in these “safe zones” they have been [attacked](#) and ordered to move to new “safe zones.”

Israel has [killed](#) at least 42,600 Palestinians in Gaza, including 13,000 children and 9,000 women. It has wounded 99,800 others, many with life-crippling injuries. It has killed at least 136 [journalists](#), many, if not most, of them deliberately [targeted](#). It has killed 340 doctors, nurses, and other health workers—four percent of Gaza's healthcare personnel. Two-hundred and thirty-three UNRWA workers have been [killed](#) in Gaza since Oct. 7, 2023, the highest death toll in U.N. history. These numbers do not begin to reflect the actual death toll since only those dead registered in morgues and hospitals, most of which no longer function, are counted. The death toll, when those who are missing are counted, is well [over 40,000](#).

At the same time, Israel has turned Gaza into a toxic wasteland.

“Nearly 40 million tons of debris, including unexploded ordnance and human remains, contaminate the ecosystem,” the U.N. reports. “More than 140 temporary waste sites and 340,000 tons of waste, untreated wastewater and sewage overflow contribute to the spread of diseases such as hepatitis A, respiratory infections, diarrhea and skin diseases.”

In a further blow, the Israeli parliament approved a bill to [ban](#) UNRWA, a lifeline for Palestinians in Gaza, from operating on Israeli territory and areas under Israel's control. The ban almost certainly ensures the collapse of aid distribution, already crippled, in Gaza.

Israel has expanded its “buffer zone” along the Gaza perimeter to 16 percent of the territory, in the process leveling homes, apartment blocks, and farms. It has pushed over 84 percent of the 2.3 million people in Gaza into “a shrinking, unsafe ‘humanitarian zone’ covering 12.6 percent of a territory now reconfigured in preparation for annexation.” Satellite imagery indicates that the Israeli military has built

roads and military bases in over 26 percent of Gaza, “suggesting the aim of a permanent presence.”

Doctors are forced to amputate limbs without anesthetic. Those with severe medical conditions—cancer, diabetes, heart disease, kidney disease—have died from lack of treatment or will die soon. Over a hundred women give birth every day with little to no medical care. Miscarriages [are up](#) by 300 percent. Over 90 percent of the Palestinians in Gaza [suffer from](#) severe food insecurity, with people eating [animal feed](#) and [grass](#). Children are [dying](#) of starvation. Palestinian writers, [academics](#), scientists, and their family members have been tracked and assassinated.

Seventy percent of recorded deaths have consistently been women and children.

Israel plays linguistic tricks to deny anyone in Gaza the status of civilians and any building—including mosques, hospitals, and schools—protected status. Palestinians are all [branded](#) as responsible for the attack on Oct. 7 or written off as human shields for Hamas. All structures are considered legitimate targets by Israel because they are allegedly Hamas [command centers](#) or are said to harbor Hamas fighters.

These accusations, Francesca Albanese, the U.N. Rapporteur for the Occupied Palestinian Territories, writes, are a “pretext” used to justify “the killing of civilians under a cloak of purported legality, whose all-enveloping pervasiveness admits only of genocidal intent.”

“In August,” Albanese writes in her most recent report, “entry permits for humanitarian organizations nearly halved. Access to water has been restricted to a quarter of pre-7 October levels. Approximately 93 percent of the agricultural, forestry, and fishing economies have been destroyed; 95 percent of Palestinians face high levels of acute food insecurity and deprivation for decades to come.”

“In recent months, 83 percent of food aid was prevented from entering Gaza, and the civilian police in Rafah were repeatedly targeted, impairing distribution,” the report notes. “At least 34 deaths from malnutrition were recorded by 14 September 2024.”

These measures, she notes, “indicate an intent to destroy its population through starvation.”

The occupation and genocide would not be sustained without the U.S., which gives Israel \$3.8 billion in annual military assistance. The U.S. has spent \$ 17.9 billion on military aid to Israel in the last 12 months, including providing 1,800 MK84 2,000-pound bombs, 500 MK82 500-pound bombs, and fighter jets to Israel. This, too, is our genocide.

The genocide in Gaza is the culmination of a process. It is not an act. The [genocide](#) is the predictable denouement of Israel's settler colonial project. It is coded within the DNA of the Israeli apartheid state. It is where Israel had to end up. And Zionist leaders are open about their goals.

We do not halt Israel's genocide because we are Israel, infected with white supremacy and intoxicated by our domination of the globe's wealth and the power to obliterate others with our industrial weapons. Remember *The New York Times* columnist [Thomas Friedman](#) telling Charlie Rose on the eve of the war in Iraq that American soldiers should go house to house from Basra to Baghdad and [say to Iraqis](#) “suck on this?” That is the real credo of the U.S. empire.

As climate change imperils survival, as resources become scarce, as migration becomes imperative for millions, as agricultural yields decline, as coastal areas are flooded, as droughts and wildfires proliferate, as states fail, as armed resistance movements rise to battle their oppressors along with their proxies, genocide will not be an anomaly. It will be the norm. The earth's vulnerable and poor, those Frantz Fanon called "the wretched of the earth," will be the next Palestinians.

The scorched earth tactics in Gaza and Lebanon are becoming common in the West Bank.

Thousands of Palestinians in the West Bank towns of Jenin, Nablus, Qalqilya, Tubas, and Tulkarem live for days under curfew, making it difficult to access food and water. As in Gaza, the Israeli army targets ambulances, blocks entrances to hospitals, and bulldozes streets, electrical, and public health infrastructure.

Drones and warplanes carry out airstrikes. Israeli roadblocks, checkpoints, and blockades make travel difficult or impossible. Israel has suspended financial transfers to the Palestinian Authority, which nominally governs the West Bank in collaboration with Israel. It has revoked 148,000 work permits for those who had jobs in Israel.

"The gross domestic product (GDP) of the West Bank contracted by 22.7 percent, nearly 30 percent of businesses have closed, and 292,000 jobs have been lost," the report reads. Over 692 Palestinians—"10 times the previous 14 years' annual average of 69 fatalities," have been killed and more than 5,000 have been injured. Of the 169 Palestinian children who have been killed, "nearly 80 percent were shot in the head or the torso."

Albanese's report dismisses the claim that Israel is assaulting Gaza and the West Bank to "defend itself," "eradicate Hamas" or "bring the hostages home," charging that these claims are "camouflage," a way of "invisibilizing the crime." Genocidal intent, as [Judge Dalveer Bhandari](#) from the ICJ points out, "may exist simultaneously with other, ulterior motives."

Rather, the incursion into Israel by Hamas and other resistance fighters on Oct. 7 "provided the impetus to advance towards the goal of a 'Greater Israel.'"

Egypt and the other Arab states have refused to consider accepting Palestinian refugees. But Israel is banking on creating a humanitarian disaster of such catastrophic proportions that these countries, or other countries, will relent so they can depopulate Gaza and turn their attention to ethnically cleansing the West Bank. That is the plan, although no one, including Israel, knows if it will work.

There is only one way to end the ongoing genocide in Gaza. It is not through bilateral negotiations. Israel has [amply demonstrated](#), including with the assassination of the lead Hamas negotiator, Ismail Haniyeh, that it has no interest in a permanent ceasefire. The only way for Israel's [genocide](#) of the Palestinians to be halted is for the U.S. to end all weapons shipments to Israel. And the only way this will take place is if enough Americans make clear they have no intention of supporting any presidential ticket or any political party that fuels this genocide.

The arguments against a boycott of the two ruling parties are familiar: It will ensure the election of Donald Trump. Kamala Harris has rhetorically shown more compassion than Joe Biden. There are not enough of us to have an impact. We can work within the Democratic Party. The Israel lobby, especially the American Israel

Public Affairs Committee (AIPAC), which owns most members of Congress, is too powerful. Negotiations will eventually achieve a cessation of the slaughter.

In short, we are impotent and must surrender our agency to sustain a project of mass killing. We must accept as normal governance the shipment of billions of dollars in [military aid](#) to an [apartheid](#) state, the use of vetoes at the U.N. Security Council to protect Israel, and the active obstruction of international efforts to end mass murder. We have no choice.

[Genocide](#), the internationally recognized crime of crimes, is not a policy issue. It cannot be equated with trade deals, infrastructure bills, charter schools, or immigration. It is a moral issue. It is about the eradication of a people. Any surrender to genocide condemns us as a nation and as a species. It plunges the global society one step closer to barbarity. It eviscerates the rule of law and mocks every fundamental value we claim to honor. It is in a category by itself. And to not, with every fiber of our being, combat genocide is to be complicit in what Hannah Arendt [defines](#) as "radical evil," the evil where human beings, as human beings, are rendered superfluous.

The fundamental lesson of the Holocaust, which writers such as Primo Levi stress, is that we can all become willing executioners. It takes very little. We can all become complicit, if only through indifference and apathy, in evil.

"Monsters exist," Levi, who survived Auschwitz, [writes](#), "but they are too few in number to be truly dangerous. More dangerous are the common men, the functionaries ready to believe and to act without asking questions."

To confront evil—even if there is no chance of success—keeps alive our humanity and dignity. It allows us, as Vaclav Havel writes in "[The Power of the Powerless](#)," to live in truth, a truth the powerful do not want to be spoken and seek to suppress. It provides a guiding light to those who come after us. It tells the victims they are not alone. It is "humanity's revolt against an enforced position" and an "attempt to regain control over one's sense of responsibility."

What does it say about us if we accept a world where we arm and fund a nation that [kills and wounds](#) hundreds of innocents a day?

What does it say about us if we support an orchestrated [famine](#) and the [poisoning](#) of the water supply where the polio virus has been [detected](#), meaning tens of thousands will get sick and many will die?

What does it say about us if we permit for over 12 months the bombing of refugee camps, hospitals, villages, and cities to wipe out families and force survivors to camp out in the open or find shelter in crude tents?

What does it say about us when we accept the [murder](#) of 11,000 children, although this is surely an [undercount](#)?

What does it say about us when we watch Israel escalate attacks on United Nations facilities, schools—including the [Al-Tabaen school](#) in Gaza City, where over 100 Palestinians were killed while performing the Fajr, or dawn prayers—and other emergency shelters?

What does it say about us when we permit Israel to use Palestinians as [human shields](#) by forcing handcuffed civilians, including children and the elderly, to enter potentially booby-trapped tunnels and buildings in advance of Israeli troops, at times dressed in Israeli military uniforms?

What does it say about us when we support politicians and soldiers who [defend the rape and torture](#) of prisoners?

Are these the kinds of allies we want to empower? Is this behavior we want to embrace? What message does this send to the rest of the world?

If we do not hold fast to moral imperatives, we are doomed. Evil will triumph. It means there is no right and wrong. It means anything, including mass murder, is permissible. Hope lies in the university encampments, in the occupation of buildings, in the hunger strikes, in the streets, and of course, in third parties that defy the empire. These people, who march to the beat of a different drummer, are the nation's conscience.

A moral stance always has a cost. If there is no cost, it is not moral. It is merely a conventional belief.

"But what of the price of peace?" the radical Catholic priest [Daniel Berrigan](#), who was sent to federal prison for burning draft records during the war in Vietnam, asks in his book *No Bars to Manhood*:

I think of the good, decent, peace-loving people I have known by the thousands, and I wonder. How many of them are so afflicted with the wasting disease of normalcy that, even as they declare for the peace, their hands reach out with an instinctive spasm in the direction of their comforts, their home, their security, their income, their future, their plans—that five-year plan of studies, that ten-year plan of professional status, that twenty-year plan of family growth and unity, that fifty-year plan of decent life and honorable natural demise. "Of course, let us have the peace," we cry, "but at the same time let us have normalcy, let us lose nothing, let our lives stand intact, let us know neither prison nor ill repute nor disruption of ties." And because we must encompass this and protect that, and because at all costs—at all costs—our hopes must march on schedule, and because it is unheard of that in the name of peace a sword should fall, disjoining that fine and cunning web that our lives have woven, because it is unheard of that good men should suffer injustice or families be sundered or good repute be lost—because of this we cry peace and cry peace, and there is no peace. There is no peace because there are no peacemakers. There are no makers of peace because the making of peace is at least as costly as the making of war—at least as exigent, at least as disruptive, at least as liable to bring disgrace and prison and death in its wake.

The question is not whether resistance is practical. It is whether resistance is right. We are enjoined to love our neighbor, not our tribe. We must have faith that the good draws to it the good, even if the empirical evidence around us is bleak. The good is always embodied in action. It must be seen. It does not matter if the wider society is censorious. We are called to defy—through [acts](#) of civil disobedience and noncompliance—the laws of the state when these laws, as they often do, conflict with moral law. We must stand, no matter the cost, with the crucified of the earth. If we fail to take this stand, whether against the abuses of militarized police, the inhumanity of our vast prison system, or the genocide in Gaza, we become the crucifiers.

"Mockery of every sort was added to their deaths," the Roman historian Tacitus wrote of those the emperor Nero singled out for torture and death. "Covered with the skins of beasts, they were torn by dogs and perished, or were nailed to crosses, or were doomed to the flames and burnt, to serve as a nightly illumination, when daylight had expired."

Sadism by the powerful is the curse of the human condition. It was as prevalent in ancient Rome as it is in Israel.

We know the modern face of Nero, who illuminated his opulent garden parties by burning to death captives tied to stakes. That is not in dispute.

But who were Nero's guests? Who wandered through the emperor's grounds as human beings, as in Rafah, were [burned alive](#)? How could these guests see, and no doubt hear, such horrendous suffering and witness such appalling torture and be indifferent, even content?

Who were Nero's guests?

We are Nero's guests.

History will judge Israel for this genocide. But it will also judge us. It will ask why we did not do more, why we did not sever all agreements, all trade deals, all accords, all cooperation with the apartheid state, why we did not halt weapons shipments to Israel, why we did not recall our ambassadors, why when Yemen disrupted the maritime trade in the Red Sea an alternative overland route into Israel was set up by Saudi Arabia and Jordan, why we did not do everything in our power to end the slaughter. It will condemn us for not heeding the fundamental lesson of the Holocaust, which is not that Jews are eternal victims but that when you have the capacity to stop genocide, and you do not, you are culpable.

"The opposite of good is not evil," Samuel Johnson wrote. "The opposite of good is indifference."

The Palestinian resistance is our resistance. The Palestinian struggle for dignity, freedom, and independence is our struggle. The Palestinian cause is our cause. For, as history has also shown, those who were once Nero's guests soon became Nero's victims.

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"To Kill a People" is a talk Chris Hedges gave at the University of California Santa Barbara at an event organized by the Green Party vice presidential nominee, Butch Ware, titled "End of Empire." It appeared first in his Substack ([The Chris Hedges Report](#)) on November 23, 2004.

The Collapse of Zionism

ILAN PAPPÉ

Hamas's assault of October 7 can be likened to an earthquake that strikes an old building. The cracks were already beginning to show, but they are now visible in its very foundations. More than 120 years since its inception, could the Zionist project in Palestine—the idea of imposing a Jewish state on an Arab, Muslim, and Middle Eastern country—be facing the prospect of collapse? Historically, a plethora of factors can cause a state to capsize. It can result from constant attacks by neighboring countries or from chronic civil war. It can follow the breakdown of public institutions, which become incapable of providing services to citizens. Often it begins as a slow process of disintegration that gathers momentum and then, in a short period of time, brings down structures that once appeared solid and steadfast.

The difficulty lies in spotting the early indicators. Here, I will argue that these are clearer than ever in the case of Israel. We are witnessing a historical process—or, more accurately, the beginnings of one—that is likely to culminate in the downfall of Zionism. And, if my diagnosis is correct, then we are also entering a particularly dangerous conjuncture. For once Israel realizes the magnitude of the crisis, it will unleash ferocious and uninhibited force to try to contain it, as did the South African apartheid regime during its final days.

1

A first indicator is the fracturing of Israeli Jewish society. At present it is composed of two rival camps which are unable to find common ground. The rift stems from the anomalies of defining Judaism as nationalism. While Jewish identity in Israel has sometimes seemed little more than a subject of theoretical debate between religious and secular factions, it has now become a struggle over the character of the public sphere and the state itself. This is being fought not only in the media but also in the streets.

One camp can be termed the 'State of Israel'. It comprises more secular, liberal and mostly but not exclusively middle-class European Jews and their descendants, who were instrumental in establishing the state in 1948 and remained hegemonic within it until the end of the last century. Make no mistake, their advocacy of 'liberal democratic values' does not affect their commitment to the apartheid system which is imposed, in various ways, on all Palestinians living between the Jordan River and the Mediterranean Sea. Their basic wish is for Jewish citizens to live in a democratic and pluralist society from which Arabs are excluded.

The other camp is the 'State of Judea', which developed among the settlers of the occupied West Bank. It enjoys increasing levels of support within the country and constitutes the electoral base that secured Netanyahu's victory in the November 2022 elections. Its influence in the upper echelons of the Israeli army and security services is growing exponentially. The State of Judea wants Israel to become a theocracy that

stretches over the entirety of historical Palestine. To achieve this, it is determined to reduce the number of Palestinians to a bare minimum, and it is contemplating the construction of a Third Temple in place of al-Aqsa. Its members believe this will enable them to renew the golden era of the Biblical Kingdoms. For them, secular Jews are as heretical as the Palestinians if they refuse to join in this endeavor.

The two camps had begun to clash violently before October 7. For the first few weeks after the assault, they appeared to shelve their differences in the face of a common enemy. But this was an illusion. The street fighting has reignited, and it is difficult to see what could possibly bring about reconciliation. The more likely outcome is already unfolding before our eyes. More than half a million Israelis, representing the State of Israel, have left the country since October, an indication that the country is being engulfed by the State of Judea. This is a political project that the Arab world, and perhaps even the world at large, will not tolerate in the long term.

2

The second indicator is Israel's economic crisis. The political class does not seem to have any plan for balancing the public finances amid perpetual armed conflicts, beyond becoming increasingly reliant on American financial aid. In the final quarter of last year, the economy slumped by nearly 20%; since then, the recovery has been fragile. Washington's pledge of \$14 billion is unlikely to reverse this. On the contrary, the economic burden will only worsen if Israel follows through on its intention to go to war with Hezbollah while ramping up military activity in the West Bank, at a time when some countries—including Turkey and Colombia—have begun to apply economic sanctions.

The crisis is further aggravated by the incompetence of Finance Minister Bezalel Smotrich, who constantly channels money to Jewish settlements in the West Bank but seems otherwise unable to run his department. The conflict between the State of Israel and the State of Judea, along with the events of October 7, is meanwhile causing some of the economic and financial elite to move their capital outside the state. Those who are considering relocating their investments make up a significant part of the 20% of Israelis who pay 80% of the taxes.

3

The third indicator is Israel's growing international isolation, as it gradually becomes a pariah state. This process began before October 7 but has intensified since the onset of the genocide. It is reflected by the unprecedented positions adopted by the International Court of Justice and the International Criminal Court. Previously, the global Palestine solidarity movement was able to galvanize people to participate in boycott initiatives, yet it failed to advance the prospect of international sanctions. In most countries, support for Israel remained unshakable among the political and economic establishment.

In this context, the recent ICJ and ICC decisions—that Israel may be committing genocide, that it must halt its offensive in Rafah, and that its leaders should be arrested for war crimes—must be seen as an attempt to heed the views of global civil

society, as opposed to merely reflecting elite opinion. The tribunals have not eased the brutal attacks on the people of Gaza and the West Bank. But they have contributed to the growing chorus of criticism leveled at the Israeli state, which increasingly comes from above as well as below.

4

The fourth interconnected indicator is the sea-change among young Jews around the world. Following the events of the last nine months, many now seem willing to jettison their connection to Israel and Zionism and actively participate in the Palestinian solidarity movement. Jewish communities, particularly in the US, once provided Israel with effective immunity against criticism. The loss, or at least the partial loss, of this support, has major implications for the country's global standing. AIPAC can still rely on Christian Zionists to provide assistance and shore up its membership, but it will not be the same formidable organization without a significant Jewish constituency. The power of the lobby is eroding.

5

The fifth indicator is the weakness of the Israeli army. There is no doubt that the IDF remains a powerful force with cutting-edge weaponry at its disposal. Yet its limitations were exposed on October 7. Many Israelis feel that the military was extremely fortunate, as the situation could have been far worse had Hezbollah joined in a coordinated assault. Since then, Israel has shown that it is desperately reliant on a regional coalition, led by the US, to defend itself against Iran, whose warning attack in April saw the deployment of around 170 drones plus ballistic and guided missiles. More than ever, the Zionist project depends on the rapid delivery of huge quantities of supplies from the Americans, without which it could not even fight a small guerrilla army in the south.

There is now a widespread perception of Israel's unpreparedness and inability to defend itself among the country's Jewish population. It has led to major pressure to remove the military exemption for ultra-Orthodox Jews—in place since 1948—and begin drafting them in their thousands. This will hardly make much difference on the battlefield, but it reflects the scale of pessimism about the army—which has, in turn, deepened the political divisions within Israel.

6

The final indicator is the renewal of energy among the younger generation of Palestinians. It is far more united, organically connected, and clear about its prospects than the Palestinian political elite. Given the population of Gaza and the West Bank is among the youngest in the world, this new cohort will have an immense influence over the course of the liberation struggle. The discussions taking place among young Palestinian groups show that they are preoccupied with establishing a genuinely democratic organization—either a renewed PLO or a new one altogether—that will pursue a vision of emancipation that is antithetical to the Palestinian Authority's

campaign for recognition as a state. They seem to favor a one-state solution to a discredited two-state model.

Will they be able to mount an effective response to the decline of Zionism? This is a difficult question to answer. The collapse of a state project is not always followed by a brighter alternative. Elsewhere in the Middle East—in Syria, Yemen, and Libya—we have seen how bloody and protracted the results can be. In this case, it would be a matter of decolonization, and the previous century has shown that post-colonial realities do not always improve the colonial condition. Only the agency of the Palestinians can move us in the right direction. I believe that, sooner or later, an explosive fusion of these indicators will result in the destruction of the Zionist project in Palestine. When it does, we must hope that a robust liberation movement is there to fill the void.

For more than 56 years, what was termed the 'peace process'—a process that led nowhere—was actually a series of American-Israeli initiatives to which the Palestinians were asked to react. Today, 'peace' must be replaced with decolonization, and Palestinians must be able to articulate their vision for the region, with Israelis asked to react. This would mark the first time, at least for many decades, that the Palestinian movement would take the lead in setting out its proposals for a post-colonial and non-Zionist Palestine (or whatever the new entity will be called). In doing so, it will likely look to Europe (perhaps to the Swiss cantons and the Belgian model) or, more aptly, to the old structures of the eastern Mediterranean, where secularized religious groups morphed gradually into ethnocultural ones that lived side-by-side in the same territory.

Whether people welcome the idea or dread it, the collapse of Israel has become foreseeable. This possibility should inform the long-term conversation about the region's future. It will be forced onto the agenda as people realize that the century-long attempt, led by Britain and then the US, to impose a Jewish state on an Arab country is slowly coming to an end. It was successful enough to create a society of millions of settlers, many of them now second- and third-generation. But their presence still depends, as it did when they arrived, on their ability to violently impose their will on millions of indigenous people, who have never given up their struggle for self-determination and freedom in their homeland. In the decades to come, the settlers will have to part with this approach and show their willingness to live as equal citizens in a liberated and decolonized Palestine.

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I am you

REFAAT ALAREER

Two steps: one, two.
 Look in the mirror:
 The horror, the horror!
 The butt of your M-16 on my cheekbone
 The yellow patch it left
 The bullet-shaped scar expanding
 Like a swastika,
 Snaking across my face,
 The heartache flowing
 Out of my eyes dripping
 Out of my nostrils piercing
 My ears flooding
 The place.
 Like it did to you
 70 years ago
 Or so.

I am just you.
 I am your past haunting
 Your present and your future.
 I strive like you did.
 I fight like you did.
 I resist like you resisted
 And for a moment,
 I'd take your tenacity
 As a model,
 Were you not holding
 The barrel of the gun
 Between my bleeding
 Eyes.

One. Two.
 The very same gun
 The very same bullet
 That had killed your Mom
 And killed your Dad
 Is being used,
 Against me,
 By you.

Mark this bullet and mark in your gun.
 If you sniff it, it has your and my blood.
 It has my present and your past.
 It has my present.
 It has your future.
 That's why we are twins,
 Same life track
 Same weapon
 Same suffering
 Same facial expressions drawn
 On the face of the killer,
 Same everything
 Except that in your case
 The victim has evolved, backward,
 Into a victimizer.
 I tell you.
 I am you.
 Except that I am not the you of now.

I do not hate you.
 I want to help you stop hating
 And killing me.
 I tell you:
 The noise of your machine gun
 Renders you deaf
 The smell of the powder
 Beats that of my blood.
 The sparks disfigure
 My facial expressions.

Would you stop shooting?
 For a moment?
 Would you?

All you have to do
 Is close your eyes
 (Seeing these days
 Blinds our hearts.)
 Close your eyes, tightly
 So that you can see
 In your mind's eye.
 Then look into the mirror.
 One. Two.
 I am you.
 I am your past.
 And killing me,
 You kill you.

Refaat Alareer (b. 1979) was killed on 7 December 2023 in his sister's home in Gaza by an Israeli airstrike. The strike also killed Alareer's brother, his sister, and her four children. Alareer was a father and a beloved professor of poetry and creative writing at the Islamic University in Gaza since destroyed by Israeli airstrikes. He was the editor of the story collection Gaza Writes Back, co-editor of the essay collection Gaza Unsilenced, and the founder of the organization We Are Not Numbers.

Source: Palestine Will Be Free (April 22, 2024):
<https://palestinewillbefree.substack.com/p/i-am-you-refaat-alarer>

The Story of the Land

SARAH ALI

To Dad

I looked at his teary eyes, and beholding something akin to happiness, I smiled. The man I have always known to be my father was back. He did not look like that unfamiliar man whom I could not fully recognize during the last three years. He was no longer that absent-minded, silent figure gazing at walls all the time and uninterestingly nodding whenever addressed by anyone at home. He was there. He was present. He was actually listening as I went on bragging about a high grade of mine. A phone call and a piece of paper signed by some Turkish-sponsored institution brought back my father. I looked at his eyes again, this time more carefully for fear that my first glance was false. As I saw that absolute happiness in my father's eyes, a big smile made it to my face again.

As we now commemorate the Land Day, we honor the people who stood up for their Land in 1976, when Israel announced thousands of Palestinian dunums would be confiscated. During marches held to protest that declaration, six people were killed. The 30th of March brings back a memory of our Land, my father's Land. A couple weeks ago, we got a phone call informing us that my father's name had been selected for a reconstruction program funded by Turkey. The program aims at helping Gazan farmers whose Lands were damaged during the Israeli offensive in 2008 to replant their trees. It provides farmers with all types of facilitating materials, such as fences, tree cuttings, seedlings, seeds, and irrigation systems. My father declined to apply for those organizations that gave financial compensations to farmers. How can he take money in return for Land? Unlike any other aid program, this program gives no money to farmers. It instead helps them stand on their own.

Though my father was born to a family of farmers, he did not follow that path. He studied economics and political science in Egypt and spent most of his youth working as a journalist, mainly a columnist, writing about economic and political issues in newspapers in Kuwait. When he was back in Gaza, though, he had to take care of the piece of Land my grandfather left for him years before. It was not difficult for him. Gradually, the Land became more of a passion than a profession. It was one of the few things he cared about, the daily thing that kept him busy. It was heaven on earth.

During those twenty-three days of the [2011] Israeli attack on Gaza, we were constantly receiving news of Land being run over by Israeli bulldozers. We were told thousands of trees were gone. We were told my uncles' trees were gone. We were told our trees were gone. We were told Sharga, the whole district of eastern farmland, was gone. But these were rumors—or so my father wanted to believe. We all had hope that our Land was still intact, totally untouched. We were clinging to the assumption that only other people's trees could get uprooted, but certainly not our beautiful, unmatched olives. Certainly not the trees that were, to my father, the only thing he

boasted of to prove he was no less of a Gazan than those who repeatedly reproached him for, as they put it, “recklessly leaving the land of black gold” where they assumed he swam in Kuwaiti oil pools every day, and for “coming to live here” with a small “h.” My father looked at it quite differently, for Here, he always believed, is the Land of al-zait al-muqaddas—the holy oil.

Gaza’s sky was blue again. Things were over—the news said things were over. My father went there. He went to check up on the Land. He put his faith in his olives being an exception, and he went there. He put his faith in that little white spot in the heart of the bulldozer’s operator who, my father supposed, could not have resisted the beauty of our Land and who listened to his innate, good being that told him not to run over this Land. He had faith in the goodness of Man and he went there. He put his faith in God and he went there. My brother, who accompanied him, told us later that all they saw as they walked was ruined Lands filled with bulldozed, dead trees which seemed to suffice for the families’ need of firewood for years to come. My brother said Dad started crying as he saw people crying. They went on. They saw more toppled trees, feeble and defeated. They went on. There was the heaven. The scene of our Land was not shocking. Simply put, our trees were no exception. Our trees were gone. A miscellany of affliction and denial took over the place. My father’s faith, I could tell, was smashed into little pieces. The world seemed like an ugly place.

One of our trees, which later became the subject matter the whole neighborhood spoke of, was still standing there. Just one week before the attacks, my father told my brother how slanted this tree was and how quickly they needed to get rid of it. They were planning to cut it, and yet, ironically, it was the only tree the Israeli army left (out of boredom or out of mercy, I cannot tell). But it was still there. Later, whenever my cousins wanted to make Dad feel less terrible about it, they made fun of the whole thing. “How the hell did the soldiers know you were planning to cut it anyway and so decided not to cut it themselves?” my cousins would remark. Everyone would start laughing. But Dad did not. His Land and olive groves are not laughing matters to him.

When my father and brother were home that day, my brother started telling us about what he saw. He told us that the trees were uprooted—“Al-shajar tjarraf,” he kept repeating. My father was in his room, crying. During the weeks that followed my father’s visit to the Land, he had a daily schedule: in the morning, he prayed and read Qur’an. At night, he cried.

Speaking about the Land, the houses, and generally the financial losses during or right after the Israeli offensive would have sounded very selfish and indifferent to others. When people are dying, you do not speak of your beautiful house that was leveled to the ground. When people are losing their legs and arms, leaving them disabled for the rest of their lives, you do not speak of your fancy car that once looked like a vase adorning the streets of your modest neighborhood and that is now a gray wreck. When a mother is burying her child before she could say good-bye, you do not speak of your Land and your trees that were mercilessly uprooted. Those people speak. They cry. They mourn. You listen. And for the memory of your insignificant, little misery, you grieve in silence. And that seemed to have amassed more agony over Dad’s pain.

Recently, I went to father to get accurate information about the trees that were uprooted, their numbers, and their age.

“Why are you asking? Are you applying for one of those charity institutions that offer some money and a bag of flour instead of helping people plant their trees again? Are you? We do not need those! The guy I met from the reconstruction program called last week, and they already sent laborers and farmers to start their job.

Do you still want to apply for charity?”

“No, Baba! I am just writing something for my blog.”

“Blog? Okay, whatever that is!”

“So, how many trees were uprooted? 180 olive trees I guess and...?”

“189 olive trees. 160 lemon trees. 14 guava trees...” he bellowed, angry that I missed the exact number.

Embarrassed, I lowered my head and wondered why I was doing this to myself. My thoughts were interrupted when he went on, “Next time you decide to do whatever it is that you want to do right now, get your numbers straight!”

I made no reply.

“You hear me? They were 189 olive trees. Not 180. Not 181. Not even 188. 189 olive trees.”

He left the room a few minutes afterwards. Guilt was all I could feel.

That an Israeli soldier could bulldoze 189 olive trees on the Land he claims is part of the “God-given Land” is something I will never comprehend. Did he not consider the possibility that God might get angry? Did he not realize that it was a tree he was running over? If a Palestinian bulldozer were ever invented (Haha, I know!) and I were given the chance to be in an orchard, in Haifa for instance, I would never uproot a tree an Israeli planted. No Palestinian would. To Palestinians, the tree is sacred, and so is the Land bearing it. And as I talk about Gaza, I remember that Gaza is but a little part of Palestine. I remember that Palestine is bigger than Gaza. Palestine is the West Bank; Palestine is Ramallah; Palestine is Nablus; Palestine is Jenin; Palestine is Tulkarm; Palestine is Bethlehem; Palestine, most importantly, is Yafa and Haifa and Akka and all those cities that Israel wants us to forget about.

Today I came to realize that it was not the phone call that brought my father back, nor was it the paper signed by the aid institution. It was the memory of the Land being revived that brought him back. It was the memory of olive trees giving that sense of security each time he sat under them, enjoying their shade and dodging the burning rays of the sun. It was the memory of the golden oil, the best and purest oil, being poured into jerry-cans and handed to family and friends as precious gifts. It was the memory of long years of cherishing the Land, years of giving and belonging.

Between my father and his Land is an unbreakable bond. Between Palestinians and their Land is an unbreakable bond. By uprooting plants and cutting trees continually, Israel tries to break that bond and impose its own rules of despair on Palestinians. By replanting their trees over and over again, Palestinians are rejecting Israel’s rules. “My Land, my rules,” says Dad.

From Gaza Writes Back, ed. Refaat Alareer, © Estate of Refaat Alareer and Just World Books 2014–2024. Reprinted with permission.



I grew up in Gaza City and started writing in Arabic at an early age; only after the 2008–9 Israeli assault on Gaza did I start to write in English. After graduating from the Islamic University of Gaza's English Department in 2013, I worked as a teacher's assistant for a year. I went on to pursue my master's degree in English Literary Studies at Durham University, UK (2014–2015). By the end of 2019, I was beginning my PhD at Cambridge University.

I first met Refaat Alareer when I was fifteen years old, and since then, I have been influenced by his wisdom, guidance, and support. Although it shut down in 2020, he ran an English Language forum that helped young Palestinians in Gaza connect with the outside world. This was before social media was popular and acted as a creative platform for us to write stories and discuss poetry as a group. At the same time, we also learned the nuances of English grammar. Some of the works in this forum went on to inspire new stories that later appeared in Gaza Writes Back.

I was honored to edit alongside Refaat on this project and was humbled to be credited in his acknowledgments in the book. We continued to pursue projects together after this, and I grew to know him as a colleague and someone who aided me in achieving my goals. Embarking on a PhD was not an easy decision to make, but Refaat supported me every step of the way and wrote my recommendation letter for Cambridge. Even in the darkest phases of PhD mental breakdowns, his patience and willingness to help grounded me and made the impossible possible. Refaat's support continued even during Israel's ongoing genocide in Gaza. When my father passed away in Gaza in December 2022, I was unable to be with my family because of the Israeli-Egyptian siege. Refaat was at my father's funeral on the first day.

I believe in the power of writing as both a way of self expression and a way of spreading the word and revealing the truth about the injustice done to the Palestinian people. To me, fighting and resisting occupation happen on different fronts, not least in the areas of journalism and media. I support Palestinian resistance in all its forms and advocate one state for its entire people, regardless of their race or religion.

It is cruel to write about a close friend's passing, but if there is anything we learned from Refaat's legacy, it is that he would not want us to wallow in grief when there was a story to tell. It is for Refaat's story, for the tale that brings hope, that we carry on.

Editor's note: We include this detailed biography for Sarah Ali, a young writer from Gaza, in hopes that it will help counter the facelessness of Palestinians struggling for freedom, self-determination, and justice. This biography is taken from the just-released [Memorial Edition of Gaza Writes Back](#) and is lightly edited for length. (see back cover)

Gaza Tells Us Who We Are

CAITLIN JOHNSTONE

Some days it's hard to say which is more horrific: the Gaza genocide itself, or the moral decay throughout our society which makes it possible.

I mean, the atrocities in Gaza have a couple million victims. If you add up the populations of the US, Europe, Canada, and Australia, you've got around a billion people living in a dystopia whose collective conscience is so warped and twisted that they'd allow their governments to support a live-streamed genocide in full view of the entire world. A billion people are so morally bankrupt that they find it tolerable for such a nightmare to be inflicted upon their fellow human beings right in front of them.

This has been especially pronounced during the heat of a US presidential race, with tens of millions of voters falling all over themselves to cognitively sweep Gaza under the carpet so they can throw their support behind one of the two mainstream candidates who've both pledged to support the Zionist state which is perpetrating this genocide. At best they see Israel's crimes as an annoying side issue which the left keeps disrupting their Kamala parties about, and at worst they support Israel's actions entirely.

What a pointless, meaningless, soulless way to live. What a betrayal of truth, and our humanity. How could anyone possibly find satisfaction in that kind of zombie-like existence? Mindlessly shuffling along to the beat of the status quo, devouring human flesh because it's more comfortable than the cognitive dissonance which would come with divorcing the power-serving worldview you've been indoctrinated from birth into espousing.

I was listening to an [interview with a doctor](#) who worked in Gaza during the genocide and he discussed the time many months ago when the IDF forced the evacuation of a hospital and left four premature babies to die in their incubators after assuring the staff they'd be taken care of. Their tiny bodies were found decomposing weeks later after Israeli forces cleared out of the area.

How did that one incident, just by itself, not stop the world? How did it not stop us all in our tracks and force us to re-evaluate everything that led to this point? It wasn't a secret that those four babies died; it was [in the mainstream news](#). It was right there, right in front of us, and we did nothing.

Such atrocities have been happening on a daily basis for thirteen months now, and still nothing.

We've got to live like this. We've got to live in this genocidal dystopia, surrounded by shambling sleepwalkers covered in human blood. Our lives here in the West are far, far more comfortable than the lives of people in Gaza, but they are also far less truthful, and far less capable of nourishing the human spirit.

We marinate in lies and psychopathy, watch lies and psychopathy, eat drink sleep, and breathe lies and psychopathy. Our minds are full of garbage and our hearts are full of shit, and we are wading around up to our ankles in the blood, sweat, and tears

of the global south. This festering sore of a civilization is the only soil in which the Western-backed genocide in Gaza could take root.

The people in Gaza have to suffer the consequences of who we are and what we have become, but we have to live with who we are and what we have become. We're killing their babies and leaving them to rot, but we're the ones who have to live with the corpses of rotting babies in our souls.

One way or another the killing in Gaza will end one day. But the forces within us which gave rise to that butchery will live on long after the sounds of the drones and explosions have ceased.

We will have to live like that. We will have to live knowing that this is who we are.

Caitlin Johnstone is a reader-funded journalist, essayist, painter, and poet in Melbourne, Australia, and the author of the illustrated poetry book Woke: A Field Guide For Utopia Preppers

This piece first appeared in Caitlin Johnstone's [Substack](#) on November 5, 2024.



Artwork by کاریکاتور حسان

How to Understand the Change of Government in Syria

VIJAY PRASHAD

One of the most stunning events of the past few months has been the fall of Damascus. This fall had initially been expected over a decade ago, when rebel armies funded by Qatar, Turkey, Saudi Arabia, and the United States crowded around the edges of Syria and threatened then President Bashar al-Assad's government. These armies, backed by rich and powerful countries, were comprised of a range of actors, including:

1. swaths of people who were angered by the economic distress caused by the opening up of the economy and the subsequent devastation of small manufacturing businesses, which were suffering in the face of the emerging might of Turkish manufacturing;
2. the peasantry in the north, frustrated by the government's lack of a proper response to the long drought that forced them into the northern cities of Aleppo and Idlib;
3. sectors of the secular petty bourgeoisie discontent with the failure of the Damascus Spring of 2000–01, which had initially promised political reforms stemming from the muntadayāt (forum discussions) held across the country;
4. a deeply aggrieved Syrian Muslim Brotherhood, formed out of the pious petty bourgeoisie, which had been crushed in 1982 and re-emerged after being inspired by the role the Brotherhood played in the 2010–11 protests in Tunisia and Egypt;
5. eager Islamist forces that had been trained by al-Qaeda in Iraq and wanted to fly the black flag of jihadism from the highest parapets in Damascus.

Despite the failure of these factions of the Syrian opposition in 2011, it was many of these same forces that succeeded in overthrowing Assad's government on 7 December 2024.

Just over a decade ago, Assad's government remained in power largely because of support from Iran and Russia, but also because of the involvement—to a lesser extent—of neighbouring Iraq and Hezbollah (Lebanon). Assad did not have the stomach for the contest. He became president in 2000 after the death of his father, Hafez al-Assad, who took office through a military coup in 1971. Bashar al-Assad had a privileged upbringing and studied to be an ophthalmologist in the United Kingdom. When the rebel armies neared Damascus in December of this year, Assad fled to Moscow with his family, claiming that he wanted to retire from politics and resume his career as an ophthalmologist. He did not make a statement to his people telling them to be brave or that his forces would fight another day. There were no comforting words. He left quietly in the same way he appeared, his country abandoned. A few days later, on Telegram, al-Assad released a text but was timid.

After being defeated by Syrian, Iranian, and Russian forces in 2014, the Syrian rebels regrouped in the city of Idlib, not far from Turkey's border with Syria. That is where the main opposition force broke with al-Qaeda in 2016, took over the local councils, and shaped itself as the only leader of the anti-Assad campaign. This group, Hayat Tahrir al-Sham (Organisation for the Liberation of the Levant, or HTS), is now in charge in Damascus.

Originating directly from al-Qaeda in Iraq, HTS has not been able to shed those roots and remains a deeply sectarian body with ambitions to eventually turn Syria into a caliphate. Since his time in Iraq and northern Syria, HTS leader Abu Mohammed al-Jolani developed a reputation of great brutality toward the large number of minority groups in Syria (specifically Alawites, Armenians, Kurds, Shi'ites), who he regarded as apostates. Al-Jolani is well-aware of his reputation, but he has remarkably altered the way he presents himself. He has shed the trappings of his al-Qaeda days; he trimmed his beard, dresses in a nondescript khaki uniform, and learned to talk to the media in measured tones. In an exclusive interview with CNN released just as his forces took Damascus, al-Jolani recalled past murderous acts committed in his name merely as youthful indiscretions. It was as if he had been trained by a public relations company. No longer the al-Qaeda madman, al-Jolani is now being presented as a Syrian democrat.

On 12 December, I spoke to two friends from minority communities in different parts of Syria. Both said that they fear for their lives. They understand that though there will be a period of jubilation and calm, they will eventually face severe attacks and have already begun hearing reports of small-scale attacks against Alawites and Shia families in their network. Another friend reminded me that there was calm in Iraq after the fall of Saddam Hussein's government in 2003; several weeks later, the insurgency began. Could such an insurgency of former government forces take place in Syria after they have recomposed from their state's hasty fall? It is impossible to know what the social fabric of the new Syria will be like given the character of the people who have taken power. This will be especially true if even a fraction of those seven million Syrians who were displaced during the war return home and seek revenge for what they will surely see as the mistreatment that forced them overseas. No war of this kind ends with peace. There are many scores yet to settle.

Without detracting attention from the Syrian people and their well-being, we must also understand what this change of government means for the region and the world. Let us take the implications sequentially, starting with Israel and ending with the Sahel region in Africa.

1. **Israel.** Taking advantage of the decade-long civil war in Syria, Israel has bombed Syrian military bases on a regular basis to degrade both the Syrian Arab Army (SAA) and its allies (notably, Iran and Hezbollah). Over the past year, during its escalation of the genocide against Palestinians, Israel has also increased its bombing of any military facility it believes is being used to resupply Iran and Hezbollah. Israel then invaded Lebanon to weaken Hezbollah, which it achieved by assassinating Hezbollah's long-time leader, Sayyed Hassan Nasrallah, and by invading southern Lebanon, where Hezbollah was rooted. As if coordinated, Israel provided air support to HTS as it moved out of Idlib, bombing Syrian mili-

tary facilities and army posts to demoralise the SAA. When HTS took Damascus, Israel strengthened its Division 210 in the Occupied Golan Heights (seized in 1973) and then invaded the United Nations buffer zone (set up in 1974). Israeli tanks proceeded outside the buffer zone and came very close to Damascus. HTS did not contest this occupation of Syria at any point.

2. **Turkey.** The Turkish government provided military and political support to the 2011 rebellion from its inception and hosted the exiled Syrian Muslim Brotherhood government in Istanbul. In 2020, when the SAA moved against the rebels in Idlib, Turkey invaded Syria to force an agreement that the city would not be harmed. Turkey also enabled the military training of most of the fighters who proceeded down highway M5 to Damascus and provided military equipment to the armies to battle the Kurds in the north and the SAA in the south. It was through Turkey that various Central Asian Islamists joined the HTS fight, including Uyghurs from China. When Turkey invaded Syria twice over the past decade, it held Syrian territory that it claimed was its historical land. This territory will not return to Syria under the HTS government.
3. **Lebanon and Iraq.** After the fall of Saddam Hussein's government in 2003, Iran built a land bridge to supply its allies in both Lebanon (Hezbollah) and Syria. With the change of government in Syria, resupplying Hezbollah will become difficult. Both Lebanon and Iraq will now border a country ruled by a former al-Qaeda affiliate. While it is not immediately clear what this means for the region, it is likely that there will be an emboldened al-Qaeda presence that wants to undermine the role of the Shia in these countries.
4. **Palestine.** The implications for the genocide in Palestine and for the struggle for Palestinian liberation are extraordinary. Given Israel's role in undermining Assad's military on behalf of HTS, it is unlikely that al-Jolani will contest Israel's occupation of Palestine or allow Iran to resupply Hezbollah or Hamas. Despite his name, which comes from the Golan, it is inconceivable that al-Jolani will fight to regain the Golan Heights for Syria. Israel's 'buffers' in Lebanon and Syria add to the regional complacency with its actions achieved by events such as its peace treaties with Egypt (1979) and Jordan (1994). No neighbour of Israel will pose a threat to it at this time. The Palestinian struggle is already experiencing great isolation from these developments. Resistance will continue, but there will be no neighbour to provide access to the means for resistance.
5. **The Sahel.** Since the United States and Israel are basically one country when it comes to geopolitics, Israel's victory is a victory for the United States. The change of government in Syria has not only weakened Iran in the short term but has also weakened Russia (a long-term strategic goal of the United States), which previously used Syrian airports to refuel its supply planes en route to various African countries. It is no longer possible for Russia to use these bases, and it remains unclear where Russian military aircraft will be able to refuel for journeys into the region, notably to countries in the Sahel. This will provide the United States with an opportunity to push the countries that border the Sahel, such as Nigeria and Benin, to launch operations against the governments of Burkina Faso, Mali, and Niger. This will require a close watch.

In July 1958, several poets organised a festival in Akka (occupied Palestine '48). One of the participating poets, David Semah, wrote 'Akhi Tawfiq' (My Brother Tawfiq), dedicated to the Palestinian communist poet Tawfiq Zayyad who was in an Israeli prison at the time of the festival. Semah's poem grounds us in the sensibility that is so sorely needed in our times:

*If they sow skulls in its dirt
Our harvest will be hope and light.*

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<https://thetricontinental.org/newsletterissue/how-to-understand-the-change-of-government-in-syria/>



Why Israel thinks it won in Syria

ASA WINSTANLEY & ALI ABUNIMAH

Israeli tanks were [reportedly](#) on the outskirts of Damascus early on Tuesday, as Israel launched airstrikes across the country that are being [called](#) “the heaviest in the history of Syria.”

The escalating Israeli attack on the country comes after President [Bashar al-Assad fled](#) to Russia in the early hours of Sunday as US- and Turkish-backed insurgents took the capital Damascus.

Benjamin Netanyahu immediately [claimed credit](#) for the fall of Assad, whose family had ruled Syria for five decades.

The Israeli prime minister's comments came as he visited the Israeli-occupied sector of Syria's Golan Heights on Sunday morning.

“This is a historic day,” Netanyahu [said](#), “a direct result of the blows we have inflicted on Iran and Hizballah, the main supporters of the Assad regime.”

Israeli occupation forces exploited the fall of the government by bombing Syria, occupying additional Syrian territories and taking out vital public infrastructure, defense equipment and airbases.

Fresh Israeli [air strikes](#) hit [Damascus and southern Syria](#), destroying “advanced weapon systems and weapons production facilities” and leaving Syria more vulnerable than ever before.

Airstrikes on the capital [appear to have targeted](#) the immigration and passport office. A huge fire was [reported](#) as consuming the [building](#).

On Monday, Reuters, [citing](#) Syrian security officials, reported that the massive Israeli air raids “bombed at least three major Syrian army air bases that housed dozens of helicopters and jets.”

The Syrian territories newly occupied by Israel [include Jabal al-Sheikh, also known as Mount Hermon](#), which lies on the Syrian border with Lebanon. Israel's government press office [emphasized](#) it was “the first time since 1973” they had occupied the area.

The Israeli prime minister also [announced](#) he was unilaterally ending the 1974 disengagement agreement between Syria and Israel, claiming that the UN-endorsed arrangement had “collapsed.”

Insurgent blitzkrieg

The downfall of Syria's government comes after an 11-day blitzkrieg, launched out of the northern enclave of Idlib, where the armed insurgents maintained a stronghold bordering Turkey since a [2016 truce](#) brokered by Russia and Turkey.

In late November, the insurgents stormed south out of Idlib through successive Syrian cities — Aleppo, Hama, Homs, and finally Damascus.

Although backed by regional and international allies, the Syrian army surrendered most of its positions without any fighting, an indication that there had been a deal assuring Assad's exit.

Outgoing US President Joe Biden [asserted on Sunday](#) that the failure of Russia, Iran, and Hizballah to defend the Syrian government was “the direct result of the blows that Ukraine [and] Israel have delivered” with the “unflagging support of the United States.”

Some analyses suggest that Iran and Russia, the Syrian government’s chief backers, concluded that the government under Assad was too hollowed out and could not be saved.

Following years of a war that caused horrific death, displacement, and destruction, Assad’s leaving without a fight spared additional bloodshed on a massive scale—at least for now.

His departure has been followed by scenes of jubilation as Syrians have reunited with loved ones from formerly cut off parts of the country or newly released from prisons.

But in a deeply divided society, many will remain in fear of what the new rulers, with their notorious record of atrocities, might bring.

In episodes reminiscent of the US invasion of Iraq in 2003, there has been [looting](#) and [revenge killings](#) of fleeing Syrian soldiers.

Libya, whose leader was toppled and killed in the US-backed 2011 insurgency, is a cautionary tale: Initial hope and jubilation were quickly dashed. Thirteen years later, the country [remains in a dire state](#) and many people fear civil war.

The US would far prefer a chaotic Syria broadly under its control to a unified country that opposes Israel.

Keeping Syria in rubble

Since 2014, the US has maintained a direct military occupation of large parts of Syria, primarily in the oil-rich northeastern region, where it is aided by local proxy militias.

When Donald Trump was president for the first time, he withdrew some of the US troops but a [reported 900 remain](#).

Dana Stroul, then a fellow at the AIPAC-affiliated Washington Institute for Near East Policy, co-chaired the bipartisan “Syria Study Group” setting out goals for US policy. She explained its recommendations in 2019 and how the US would aim to weaken the Syrian state and immiserate its people.

The first goal, Stroul said, was to maintain the US military occupation of the most “resource rich” one-third of Syrian territory, encompassing its oil fields and its “agricultural powerhouse.”

In addition to “diplomatic and political isolation of the Assad regime,” Stroul emphasized the importance of US economic sanctions and preventing the war-torn country from rebuilding.

Most of Syria, [Stroul said](#), “is rubble.”

The commission she co-chaired recommended, as she put it, that the United States use its enormous international leverage to “hold the line on preventing reconstruction aid and technical expertise from going back into Syria.”

From 2021-2023, she had a direct hand in implementing these policies as deputy assistant secretary of defense for the Middle East—the Pentagon’s top civilian official for the region.

Stroul is now [back at the Washington Institute](#), the Israel lobby’s most influential think tank, as director of research.

The US has for years been working hard to dominate Syria’s material wealth.

Rebranded al-Qaida

The lightning offensive from Idlib was led by Hayat Tahrir al-Sham, which [emerged out of al-Qaida](#).

The group’s leader is Abu Muhammad al-Julani—formerly the leader of Jabhat al-Nusra, the al-Qaida affiliate in Syria and once an [emissary from the Islamic State of Iraq](#) (which later became ISIS).

Under al-Julani, Jabhat al-Nusra carried out numerous atrocities against Syrian civilians, according to human rights groups.

Human Rights Watch [investigated](#) rebel atrocities in the coastal region around the city of Latakia and in a 2013 report stated that al-Nusra and its allied groups carried out “premeditated and organized” war crimes, including “the systematic killing of entire families.”

Nor did such abuses stop with the rebranding to Hayat Tahrir al-Sham.

Human Rights Watch [says](#) it has documented severe abuses by Hayat Tahrir al-Sham in the Idlib enclave it has controlled in recent years.

“Hayat Tahrir al-Sham’s crackdown on perceived opposition to their rule mirrors some of the same oppressive tactics used by the Syrian government,” Lama Fakih, the human rights group’s deputy Middle East director said in 2019. “There is no legitimate excuse for rounding up opponents and arbitrarily detaining and torturing them.”

In March, VOA [reported](#) that protests erupted over several days in about 20 locations in the Idlib enclave.

“Protesters chant slogans against HTS leader Abu Muhammad al-Julani, demanding the release of prisoners held by the extremist group and an end to its security grip on the enclave,” the US government-funded media network said.

Another [uprising](#) broke out in May against Hayat Tahrir al-Sham’s “increasingly dictatorial” rule, including allegedly torturing prisoners to death.

In a [statement](#) on Sunday following the fall of the Damascus government, Human Rights Watch accused Assad of “countless atrocities, crimes against humanity, and other abuses during his 24-year presidency.” It also said that Hayat Tahrir al-Sham and other “non-state armed groups” that “launched the offensive” from Idlib on 27 November, are responsible “for human rights abuses and war crimes.”

Al-Julani has never been held to account.

On the contrary, US and British officials are [reportedly discussing](#) the possibility of [removing him](#) and his group from their [designated terror lists](#).

It even seems likely that al-Julani has been groomed to lead Syria, as Western media are working hard to whitewash his image with [sympathetic interviews](#) and [coverage](#).

These rebranding efforts rely on assertions that al-Julani and Hayat Tahrir al-Sham have left their past behind.

But that wasn't always the view. The US government itself [asserted](#) in 2017 that "HTS is a merger and any group that merges into it becomes part of al-Qaida's Syrian network."

It was on that basis that the United States placed a \$10 million bounty on al-Julani—whose real name is [Ahmed al-Shara](#)—a reward that officially [remains available](#) to anyone who can help the FBI locate him.

Biden admits funding of al-Qaida-linked groups

Over the last 13 years, the various armed groups working together to overthrow the Syrian government have been backed by the US, Gulf states, Turkey, and [Israel](#) itself.

In a rare [moment of honesty](#)—one he later [had to apologize](#) for—then US Vice President Joe Biden admitted in 2014 that the surge of funding had aided groups the US considers extremists.

Biden said that Turkey, Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates, Qatar, and others "were so determined to take down Assad and essentially have a proxy Sunni-Shia war... [that] they poured hundreds of millions of dollars, tens, thousands of tons of weapons into anyone who would fight against Assad."

"Except that the people who were being supplied were al-Nusra and al-Qaida and the extremist elements of jihadis coming from other parts of the world," Biden added.

What Biden did not mention is Operation Timber Sycamore, the [massive](#) amount of US funding and training that the CIA, under President Barack Obama, also poured into the [multibillion dollar](#) Syria proxy war.

In 2017, *The New York Times* [called this](#) "one of the costliest covert action programs in the history of the CIA."

The logic was well summed up by Jake Sullivan, currently Biden's national security adviser, in a 2012 email to then Secretary of State Hillary Clinton.

"AQ [Al-Qaida] is on our side in Syria," Sullivan [wrote](#).

Axis of Resistance setback

The last time al-Qaida and other insurgent groups were present in the Golan Heights, Israel established warm relations with them, treating their fighters in a [specially constructed field hospital and even arming them](#).

Netanyahu on Sunday signaled the revival of that policy. He [said](#) that Israel would pursue "the same approach we maintained when we set up a field hospital here that treated thousands of Syrians injured during the civil war. Hundreds of Syrian children were born here in Israel."

Since Syria was for decades the backbone of the Axis of Resistance to US hegemony and Israeli settler-colonialism, many in the region view Assad's downfall as a major strategic win for Israel and the US.

Syria was a [vital link in the military supply chain](#)—a land bridge between Iran and its regional ally Hizballah. That Lebanese resistance faction ousted Israeli occupation forces from South Lebanon in 2000 and repelled the attempted Israeli ground invasion which began at the start of October this year.

The Israeli ground offensive concluded at the end of November with an [uneven truce](#) which Israel has already violated more than 100 times, [according to the UN](#).

Israel was reportedly desperate for a ceasefire with Hizballah, since its invasion was unable to proceed more than a few kilometers from the border and its military was unable to hold any territory.

Its troops were simply beaten by superior Lebanese fighters.

Only hours after Damascus fell to the insurgents, Israel launched a new incursion into Syria, Israeli media [reported](#) on Sunday.

Israeli tanks and soldiers occupied new Syrian land in the Golan Heights, calling it a "buffer zone." Israel has occupied most of Syria's southwestern Golan region since its invasion of 1967—expelling [most of the Syrian population there](#).

Israel unilaterally annexed the occupied Syrian territory in 1981 and has colonized the land with [about 20,000 settlers](#).

Pro-Israel insurgents?

Assad's opponents are celebrating what they hope will be a new dawn for Syria. But many people in the region view the insurgents' offensive as deliberately timed to aid Israel.

Netanyahu's claim of responsibility for the fall of Damascus to the insurgents on Sunday morning will only reinforce that view.

Former al-Qaida leader al-Julani, for his part, sounds almost like a pro-Israel lobbyist. In one [recent video](#) he made reference to what he termed "Iran's wars against the region"—echoing language frequently used by Netanyahu since October 2023.

Al-Qaida and other similar groups tend to view the region through an extremist Sunni Muslim sectarian lens, considering Shia Muslim-majority Iran and the Shia Muslim group Hizballah as mortal enemies. Whether tacitly or openly, that allows such groups to make common cause with Israel and the United States—as US official Jake Sullivan acknowledged in his notorious 2012 email.

"We were very happy when you attacked Hizballah," one "opposition activist" recently told an Israeli journalist who [aired his comments](#) on TV. "We are happy to help you," the activist added. "We love the state of Israel and we have never been its enemy, because it doesn't harm anyone if no one harms it."

In [another interview](#) with *The Times of Israel*, one "rebel commander" told the news site that his US-backed Free Syrian Army were ready to normalize relations with Israel—despite the ongoing Israeli genocide against the Palestinians and the decades-long illegal Israeli occupation of Syrian territory.

"We will go for full peace with Israel," the commander said. "Since the outbreak of the Syrian civil war, we have never made any critical comments against Israel, unlike Hizballah, who stated they aim to liberate Jerusalem and the Golan Heights."

The insurgent commander speaking to the Israeli news site also hinted that he may already have been in contact with Israeli officials.

Even if these unidentified figures are not speaking officially, such whitewashing of the genocidal Israeli regime will not fill Palestinians with hope, especially those in Gaza.

[Speaking](#) to an Israeli TV channel, Israeli military intelligence officer Mordechai Kedar said that he is "in constant contact with the leaders of the Syrian opposi-

tion factions ... They are ready for a peace agreement with Israel, only if they get to control Syria and Lebanon.”

Such statements will alarm people in Lebanon as a warning that their country could be the next target, part of an effort to draw Hizballah into a civil war.

“Leaders of Syrian opposition factions have conveyed to Tel Aviv that they are planning to open an Israeli embassy in Damascus and Beirut,” Kedar claimed.

Reporting on the comments of another “rebel commander” to Israeli government broadcaster Channel 12, *The Times of Israel* [noted](#) last week that the “offensive was launched just as a ceasefire went into effect” between Israel and Hizballah.

According to this commander, the timing was no coincidence.

“We looked at the [ceasefire] agreement with Hizballah and understood that this is the time ... We will not let Hizballah fight in our areas and we will not let the Iranians take root there,” he said.

The commander said his goal was to replace the Syrian government with one that has good relations with Israel, the news site reported.

Some of this might be spin, wishful thinking or outright fabrication. But given more than a decade of US backing for these groups, their sponsors clearly consider them much preferable to groups whose declared goal is resistance to Israel.

Sectarian plots

The newly dominant insurgents have longstanding grudges against the resistance.

Hizballah intervened in Syria [in 2013](#) after the US proxy war against the country that began two years earlier came close to toppling the government in Damascus.

The group and its Axis of Resistance ally Iran—along with Russia, which has military bases in the country—prevented the government from being overthrown.

With the militias that have taken over Syria now in a position to dominate the country, the future of the resistance axis is uncertain.

Some Israeli planners are plotting to carve up Syria into warring ethnic and sectarian cantons—a classic colonial divide and rule strategy.

In an [interview published](#) by *The Times of Israel* on Monday, Israeli military intelligence colonel Wahabi Anan Wahabi laid out his plan for what the news site described as “a loose confederation of four ethnic substates.”

Wahabi said that “the country is already divided into four cantons. The next step is to make this division official.”

“The modern nation-state has failed in the Middle East,” he claimed.

“American-Israeli emergency plan”

The US closely coordinated the Idlib offensive with Israel.

An [informed source told](#) [Said Arikat](#), the respected Washington correspondent of the Palestinian newspaper *Al-Quds*, that the Hayat Tahrir al-Sham offensive was planned in coordination with the US, Israel and Turkey.

It “came as a result of an American-Israeli ‘emergency plan’ coordinated by the administration of President Joe Biden with Turkey” and that it “was implemented according to an American vision for the day after the ceasefire agreement between Lebanon and Israel.”

Arikat wrote that his source had previously trained insurgents including the al-Qaida affiliate Jabhat al-Nusra and its successor Hayat Tahrir al-Sham in bases in Jordan and Turkey until 2021.

The Israeli invasion on Sunday appears to have been in preparation for some time.

Only one week before the Hayat Tahrir al-Sham offensive was launched, Israeli media reported that the chief of the Shin Bet, Israel’s secret police, [had been in Turkey for a meeting](#) with the head of a Turkish intelligence agency.

Also one week before the offensive, [Israel began new illegal construction](#) in the demilitarized zone between the Syrian-controlled and the Israeli-occupied sectors of the Golan Heights in violation of the 1974 disengagement agreement.

According to [UNDOF](#), the United Nations peacekeeping force which monitors the ceasefire, these were “severe violations.”

Syrians, regardless of their political outlook, will want to see their country back on its feet, united and independent as soon as possible. No supporter of Palestinian liberation has anything to fear from a truly sovereign Syria.

That is precisely why there are many powerful outside forces, principally Israel and the United States, who want Syria to remain weak and become subservient to their agenda. If division, dependency and chaos are the only ways to achieve that, then that is what they will foster and foment.

Israel, for its part, is wasting no time capitalizing on the tumultuous and historic events to seize more land and consolidate its genocidal grip on the region.

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[<https://electronicintifada.net/content/why-israel-thinks-it-won-syria/50205>]

Pessimism, Optimism, and the Role of Intellectuals

GARY OLSON

The challenge of modernity is to live life without illusions and without becoming disillusioned... I'm a pessimist because of intelligence, but am an optimist because of will. —Antonio Gramsci (1891- 1937)

Back on December 10, 2016, after 45 years of college teaching, I met my last class. The course was *Intro to International Politics: How the World Works*. After twelve weeks of exposing countless myths, fables, and misinformation the odds of changing the world seemed daunting at best. If ignorance is bliss, there were few blissful days in the course, and early on, I mentioned that my mother not infrequently referred to her oldest son as “Dr. Gloom and Doom!” Per usual, I felt responsible to leave my students with some sense of hope, but it had to be honest and not mawkish, anemic, liberal bromides.

Although my classes were invariably discussion-oriented, on that occasion, I chanced the students would tolerate a mini-lecture. After waiting a full minute to get their attention, I wrote Gramsci’s aphorism on the board and took it as my point of departure. Here’s a synopsis of my comments for your possible interest:

British historian E.J. Hobsbawm described Antonio Gramsci as “an extraordinary philosopher, perhaps a genius, probably the most original communist thinker of the 20th century in Western Europe.” Born on the island of Sardinia into a recently impoverished family, Gramsci had experienced the conditions he was to write about. As a revolutionary socialist and co-founder of the Italian Communist Party, his effectiveness as a radical thinker, journalist, agitator, and organizer led to his arrest and imprisonment by Benito Mussolini’s fascist regime in 1926. The charge was treason — attempting to “undermine the Italian state.”

Mussolini had once referred to Gramsci as “this Sardinian hunchback and professor of economics and philosophy” who possessed “an unquestionably powerful brain.” At his trial the government prosecutor pointed directly at Gramsci and famously proclaimed, “For twenty years we must stop this brain from functioning” and that was sentence. The serious health problems that plagued Gramsci’s entire life continued as he spent most of the remainder of his life in prison.

When his health deteriorated to a life-threatening situation, he was moved to prison clinics in 1933 and 1937. Just prior to gaining his freedom in April 1937, he succumbed to a stroke at age 46. While in prison, he wrote his justly famous *Prison Notebooks* (34 volumes) and 3,000 pages of handwritten notes.

In 1929, writing from his prison cell, Gramsci tried to put his youngest brother Carlo’s fears to rest with these words:

You must realize that I am far from feeling beaten...it seems to me that... a man out to be deeply convinced that the source of his own moral force is in himself—his very energy and will, the iron coherence of ends and means—that he never falls into those vulgar, banal moods,

pessimism and optimism. My own state of mind synthesizes these two feelings and transcends them: my mind is pessimistic, but my will is optimistic. Whatever the situation, I imagine the worst that could happen in order to summon up all my reserves and willpower to overcome every obstacle.¹

For Gramsci “the crisis” of his time and by extension our own, arises from the fact that the old order is expiring but the new one cannot be born. In the intervening period, certain “morbid symptoms” emerge. Most importantly, there is no guarantee the new order will be better or worse than the present one and it could be catastrophically worse.

One need not look far today to justify pessimism of the intellect, for Gramsci’s “morbid symptoms.” Decision-making in the U.S. remains in the hands of massive private tyrannies; the systematic undoing of reformist concessions wrung from capitalists has accelerated; endless wars; millions of plant and animal extinctions; four decades of neoliberal ideology has produced an empathy deficit disorder of epic proportions; a record number of desperate refugees around the world; ecocide, euphemistically called “climate change” looms; the populist right is gaining political ascendancy around the globe; political manipulation and manufacture of consent have attained unprecedented levels; the U.S. empire is in decline, and therefore its incomparable power is even more dangerous; and with the world seemingly in its death throes, the minuscule radical left in this country shows unmistakable signs of ossification.

On a personal level, claiming to face things as they really exist mandates looking into the abyss and acknowledging that my life’s work may have been extraneous, perhaps doomed to irrelevancy. Put another way, being right about so many things hasn’t counted for nearly as much as I’d assumed when much younger. The awareness that my own government is responsible for most of the world’s overt and structural violence is a background thrum in my life and often leaves me feeling like a stranger in my own country.

Based on extensive exchanges with Facebook friends, I know I’m hardly alone in this respect. I should quickly add that these numerous, far-flung contacts remain an essential source of sustenance for me, and I encouraged my students to seek out friends and associations with shared commitments. If memory serves, I said that living life without illusions means being liberated from the brain-washing worldview imposed (and conveniently believed) by our rulers. That’s life-affirming and no small achievement. Finally, participating in struggles for justice brings rewards that simply can’t be experienced anywhere else.

What then, is pessimism of the intellect? It’s seeing the world as it actually exists, not some fantasy about how we’d like it to be. It means not accepting things at face value and doubting what we’ve heard since childhood in the absence of evidence. In short, it’s pretty much what they’d heard before taking the class. In terms of optimism of the will, Gramsci means that humans have the capacity to overcome new challenges, courageously move forward, and create a better world in the face of very long odds. We can’t predict the course of history, but human agency is paramount and history is made by human will.

Here I hesitate to introduce the troublesome term “intellectual” but it bears directly on our subject. A major focus of Gramsci’s work was on the role of intellectuals in organizing culture. Pessimism of the intellect requires discerning the truth about politics. However, Gramsci knew that “to say truth is revolutionary” but the reality is that most intellectuals speak untruths to the powerless. In his time, Gramsci observed this was so effective that “when truth is actually spoken, no one believes it.”²

According to Gramsci, it would be a grievous error to believe such matters are somehow only within the purview of individuals commonly referred to as “intellectuals.” Gramsci wrote about what he called “organic intellectuals” who emerge out of their socioeconomic milieu. For the working class, arriving at a pessimism of the intellect and engaging in critical thinking are activities that can be performed by many different people depending on the occasion. It’s not about pedigrees, those possessing ‘superior powers of intellect,’ certain writing skills or eloquence, or special vocations. To be sure, affluence, leisure time, and opportunity all factor in, but “working-class intellectual” is not an oxymoron.

“These organic intellectuals are distinguished less by their profession, which may be any job characteristic of their class, than by their function in directing the ideas and aspirations of the class to which they rightly belong.”³ This is what Gramsci meant by stating “all men are philosophers” or all individuals are intellectuals, in capacity if not always function. Different classes midwife their own intellectuals, and the working class is fully capable of generating its own organic intellectuals in this broad sense of the term. The anthropologist Cate Crehan, a close student of Gramsci’s work, reminds those of us intent on radical change must be mindful that counter-narratives “emerge out of the lived realities of oppressed people’s day-to-day living.”⁴

I also reviewed Noam Chomsky’s position that most people we call ‘intellectuals’ are a special class of people who are lavishly rewarded for imposing the ideas of those in power on the rest of us. And that “...the population should be anti-intellectual in that respect. I think that’s a healthy reaction.” He’s suggesting that people need to develop an “intellectual self-defense” against these ‘intellectuals.’ Chomsky goes on to assert, “I suspect that plenty of people in the crafts, auto mechanics and so on, probably do as much or more intellectual work than people in the universities...if by ‘intellectual’ you mean people who are using their minds, then it’s all over society.”⁵

For me, Paul Baran, the late Marxist professor of economics at Stanford University, adds to this more nuanced, more inclusive view when he asserts that to be an intellectual is to be a social critic, someone who identifies, analyzes and helps “to overcome the obstacles barring the way to the attainment of a better more humane, and more rational social order.”⁶ To be sure, such a person will be treated as a nuisance and a troublemaker by those in power, and it takes courage and commitment to withstand social pressure. However, echoing Gramsci, Baran makes the essential point that this understanding of “intellectual” includes all sorts of people from many walks of life.

What happens in the absence of optimism of the will? We already see it. Some people adopt a breezy, banal optimism that Gramsci describes as “nothing but a way to defend one’s laziness, irresponsibility, and unwillingness to do anything.”⁷ More common is an enveloping sense of impotence, fatalism, and withdrawing into one-

self to fend off further despair, a voluntary disengagement that University of Texas journalism professor Robert Jensen identifies as “the ultimate exercise of privilege.”⁸

Toward the end of the last session, I said that during my career I’d tried to help students see through all the bullshit and grasp how the world works. I would not have remained a teacher if I hadn’t wagered it should and could work much better. I reminded them of our first week’s discussion that human nature has revealed a continuum of behaviors from the most wretched and cruel to the most compassionate and empathetic. At a minimum, this means, in the words of Amin Maalouf, “There is a Mr. Hyde inside each of us. What we have to do is prevent the conditions that bring the monster forth.” Call it optimism of the will or the heart, but to try to live life as we think humans should live—as the world should work—is a choice.

Chomsky put it this way: “You basically have two choices. You can say ‘Nothing is going to change, so I am going to do nothing.’ You can therefore guarantee that the worst possible outcome will come about. Or, you can take the other position. You can say: ‘Look, maybe something will work. Therefore, I will engage myself in trying to make it work and maybe there’s a chance things can get better.’ That is your choice. Nobody can tell you how right it is to be optimistic. Nothing can be predicted about human affairs...nothing.”⁹ It doesn’t contradict Chomsky’s assertion to conclude that failure to engage today will provide a definitive answer to Rosa Luxemburg’s famous question: Will we be transitioning to socialism or barbarism?

(Thanks to Kathleen Kelly, my comrade and in-house editor, for her tough love critiques.)

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Endnotes

- 1 Antonio Gramsci, *Letters from Prison* (New York: Harper & Row, 1973) pp.158–59.
- 2 *Prison Notebooks*, Edited by V. Gerratano, Turin, 1975, p. 699.
- 3 Selections from *The Prison Notebooks of Antonio Gramsci* edited and translated by Quentin Hoare and Geoffrey Nowell Smith, 1991, p 131..
- 4 Cate Crehan, *Gramsci, Culture and Anthropology* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2002), p.
- 5 Both quotes from Noam Chomsky, *Understanding Power*, Edited by Peter R. Mitchell and John Schoeffel, (New York: Harper & Row, 2002) p.96
- 6 Paul Baran, “The Commitment of the Intellectual,” *Monthly Review* (May 1961)
- 7 Gramsci, *Prison Notebooks*, Number 9
- 8 Although written fifteen years ago, there’s arguably no more succinct and more accessible source for ‘pessimist of the intellect but optimist of the will’ than to consult Robert Jensen’s *Citizens of the Empire*. (San Francisco: City Lights, 2004).
- 9 Face to Face with a Polymath, *Frontline*, November 2001.

The Cost of Disobeying the Empire: Upheaval for Bangladesh

ASHA ZAVAREEN

During the summer of 2024, the world witnessed a student-led movement in Bangladesh come to a head when the then-Prime Minister, Sheikh Hasina, resigned and fled to India, followed by the installation of Muhammad Yunus as head of the interim government. This seemingly positive change has complex implications regarding national sovereignty and foreign influence in domestic affairs. The exit of Hasina and the Awami League, followed by the new appointment of Muhammad Yunus, may seem like a win for the Bangladeshi population. Still, a closer inspection of the events that have transpired begs wariness from the people of the Global South.

Since Bangladesh fought and won its independence from Pakistan in 1971, a [quota system](#) was in place reserving 30% of public sector jobs for those who fought in the liberation War and, since 1997, their children and, since 2010, their grandchildren. Quotas have also been in place for various disadvantaged and underrepresented groups. In Bangladesh, government positions are highly coveted and more sought out than private sector positions due to the former offering job security, social prestige, pensions, and a lighter workload. The quota system, intended to address historical injustices, soon became a flashpoint as economic realities and youth unemployment intensified tensions. The youth unemployment rate, the percentage of persons between the ages of 15 and 24 who are actively looking for work but are not currently employed, has steadily climbed since 2010 and reached [a high](#) of 15.74% in 2023. Thus, the quota system has been a point of contention for many years, with student protest movements breaking out in 2008, 2013, 2018, and most recently in the summer of 2024.

To avoid an escalation of the student protest movement seeking to reform the quota system, Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina announced in 2018 that the quotas would be abolished for mid- and high-level executive and administrative roles, also known as first- and second-class posts. At the time, 30% of government jobs were [reserved](#) for the descendants of freedom fighters, 10% for women, 10% for candidates from underdeveloped districts, 5% for ethnic minorities, and 1% for the disabled, leaving 44% reserved for fully merit-based appointments. The decision to abolish the quota system was made effective in 2020 despite the student movement's goal of reforming the quota system and its [disavowal](#) of complete abolition. Tensions returned when, on June 5, 2024, Bangladesh's High Court reinstated the quota system, declaring the 2018 decision illegal. Sheikh Hasina's administration appealed this decision and was able to [obtain](#) a status quo order from the Appellate Division of the Supreme Court on July 10, 2024. The status quo order would reinstate the quota system but keep [quota positions](#) at 7%, with 5% reserved for descendants of freedom fighters.

Nationwide protests had moved beyond demands regarding the quota system and were now calling for Hasina's resignation in part due to harsh and violent gov-

ernment responses to the protests that led to the deaths of hundreds of protesters. The situation continued to escalate, and on August 5, as the protesters marched to Hasina's residence, reports of her resignation and flight to India reached the public. The next day, Muhammad Yunus, Nobel Peace Laureate and long-running chairman of the microfinance company known as Grameen Bank, was [appointed](#) as Chief Advisor, the head of the Interim Government of Bangladesh.

While the reform of the quota system and the resignation of Sheikh Hasina may seem like a triumph for the protesters, the subsequent appointment of Muhammad Yunus raises significant concerns. Yunus, a Nobel Peace Laureate with longstanding ties to Western institutions, was quickly installed as the interim Prime Minister—a move that has sparked debate about the real forces at play in this political shift. In a region historically wary of foreign influence, this development reflects a familiar pattern in other revolutions, where external powers, particularly the United States, exploit domestic unrest to position leaders more favorable to their geopolitical interests. The events in Bangladesh serve as a reminder of how genuine calls for change can be co-opted, making it critical for the Global South to remain vigilant against the subtle imposition of foreign-backed political change.

United States Involvement in the Movement

In recent years, Sheikh Hasina and her cabinet made several moves that undermined the geopolitical interests of the United States. She and her party, the Awami League, significantly improved ties with both China and India, aiming to formally join the BRICS nations.

BRICS is a grouping of emerging economies founded in 2009 on the premise that the international system is dominated by institutions serving the interests of Western powers and corporations at the expense of the nations of the Global South. By forming a bloc, BRICS aims to increase its influence in the global system and better serve the interests of the global majority. The group seeks to create alternative institutions to those established by the U.S. after the Second World War, such as the International Monetary Fund and the World Bank. A key goal is to reduce or replace reliance on the U.S. dollar and challenge the economic sanctions wielded by the G7 bloc against nations perceived as threats to Western military and economic dominance. Today, BRICS comprises Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa, Iran, Egypt, Ethiopia, and the United Arab Emirates. Unsurprisingly, U.S. officials view the BRICS as a challenge to the institutional structure of the global order that favors Western corporate interests.

In September of 2021, Bangladesh, under Sheikh Hasina's administration, [joined](#) the New Development Bank, the multilateral development bank established by BRICS. Hasina has emphasized the need for increased trade in local currencies to reduce dependency on the U.S. dollar, a sentiment echoed by the Asian Clearing Union (ACU), which recently agreed at a summit in Iran to launch a cross-border financial messaging system to rival the U.S.-controlled SWIFT payment network. Amongst ACU members are Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Pakistan, and Iran. To add insult to injury for the United States, Bangladesh's growing ties with China and Russia have seen the country increasingly use the Chinese currency, the renminbi, in commerce with Russia, especially after Western sanctions prevented Bangladesh from paying Russia in dollars for building a nuclear power plant. As de-dollarization

accelerates across the globe, Bangladesh's strategic moves under Hasina's administration reflected its broader ambition to lessen reliance on the U.S. dollar and strengthen its ties with alternative economic powers.

At a press conference in June of 2023, Hasina [announced](#): "We will join anything that benefits us. We are bound to do everything that is favorable for our people. The time has gone where there was no option but to lean on one party or take a side." In the same statements made to the press, Hasina also announced that she would refuse to sell St. Martin's Island to maintain her power. At the time, Hasina did not specify which foreign entity sought to control St. Martin's Island, but following her resignation, she reportedly told her close associates that had she conceded the island to the U.S., she would still be in power. The island would offer the U.S. access to the Bay of Bengal and allow the U.S. military to block off the Strait of Malacca, a narrow stretch of water that serves as an entryway to the South China Sea for most of China's oil imports. St. Martin's Island also offers a major strategic advantage for the U.S. in its New Cold War with China as the location would allow surveillance of regional trade.

Under Hasina, Bangladesh made significant progress in relationships with India, China, and Russia—three key BRICS members, with China and Russia as political rivals of the United States. Improving ties between these countries leaves them less vulnerable and, therefore, less likely to acquiesce to exploitative demands from Western nations, especially the U.S. In December 2023, Russia's embassy in Bangladesh released a statement warning of "instigating activities of Western diplomatic missions in Dhaka," backing violent protests and predicting an "Arab Spring"-style color revolution. This prediction echoed concerns voiced by Russian Foreign Ministry Spokesperson Maria Zakharova, who highlighted the risk of impending destabilization of Bangladesh, not a far-fetched concern given the US record of staging or abetting multiple coups, regime changes, and destabilizations aimed at punishing countries that defy its desires.

When periods of tumult arise in a country with a ruling government that is not fully subservient to the U.S., Western audiences are immediately exposed to a litany of news stories showcasing purported evidence of an authoritarian government. The mainstream U.S. and Western press ignore any popular support for such an administration and often exclusively interview a propertied or monied segment of the population. The public is led to believe that such a government must be overthrown or destabilized and replaced with a U.S.-friendly government. Bangladesh was no exception to this pattern.

On July 10, 2024, a little more than a month after the beginning of the protests opposing the quota ruling, the U.S. State Department's Bureau of Economic and Business Affairs published a report detailing Bangladesh's investment climate. The report claimed that "Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina and her ruling party, the Awami League, adopted legislation and policies that diminished space for the political opposition, undermined judicial independence, and threatened freedom of the media and civil society. Hasina, on January 7, 2024, was re-elected to her fourth consecutive term in an election assessed to be neither free nor fair amid jailing thousands of the opposition, mass opposition election boycotts, voting irregularities, and low

voter turnout." The report was released during mounting protests and reflected the U.S.'s critical stance on Hasina's administration by highlighting alleged democratic backsliding. Such a portrayal prepared the ground for a leadership change favoring Western interests, underscoring the fine line between advocacy for democracy and interference in sovereign governance. Western media outlets championed the overthrow of Hasina in August and framed it as a shift toward the democratization of Bangladesh and an end to a dictatorship, all the while refraining from questioning the installation of an unelected Yunus.

Considering Yunus's history, his swift appointment as interim leader raises critical questions. Yunus had gained international recognition for his work with Grameen Bank, a microfinance institution purportedly established to aid Bangladesh's impoverished population. Microfinance has long since been shown to be ineffective, leaving many borrowers worse off than before. Loan recipients are often unable to repay their loans, and the interest rates are often exorbitant—sometimes [exceeding](#) 90% annually—making microfinance nothing more than a loan shark scheme preying on the most vulnerable segments of society. Despite the humanitarian image based on the false notion that microfinance is an effective antidote to poverty, Yunus's relationship with Western governments—particularly the U.S.—complicates his role in the recent regime change. Grameen Bank was founded with partial Bangladeshi government ownership, allowing the state regulatory oversight of its leadership. However, leaked diplomatic cables from 2009 reveal Yunus's meeting with U.S. Ambassador James F. Moriarty, during which he sought assistance to sidestep government authority, ensuring his indefinite control of Grameen Bank.

Over the years, Yunus established connections with prominent U.S. officials, including U.S. President Joe Biden, Secretary of State Antony Blinken, and USAID Administrator Samantha Power. He was recently honored by his longtime friend Bill Clinton at the Clinton Global Initiative for his role in microfinance, a predatory neoliberal practice that has long been promoted by Hilary Clinton. When Yunus was removed as chairman of Grameen Bank by the government of Bangladesh in March of 2011, Hilary Clinton spoke out against the move, claiming she was concerned such a decision would interfere with the bank's "tremendous model." During Clinton's tenure as Secretary of State, she met with Yunus multiple times, most notably in May of 2012 when she expressed public support for him in opposition to Sheikh Hasina's decision.

These relationships with powerful U.S. officials suggest a preference among Western powers for Yunus, given his alignment with neoliberal economic models and Western diplomatic goals. Yunus's advocacy for microfinance, often viewed as a countermeasure to state programs, reflects neoliberal ideologies that promote market solutions. Microfinance provides loans to those in poverty, encouraging them to start small businesses. However, the idea that all the world's woes would be solved if everyone were to become an entrepreneur is far from the truth. Yunus's exploitative microfinance model even expanded into the U.S. with Grameen America, where the bank charges struggling members of Black, Indigenous, and Latin American communities [an 18% interest rate on loans](#). Many poor farmers in the Global South are forced to sell what little land they till for survival to repay microfinance loans. India was faced with [a wave of suicides](#) in the early 2010s when hundreds of borrowers were

forced to sell necessities and were sometimes even encouraged by loan agents to sell their children.

Muhammad Yunus was an early pioneer of the microfinance model and received his Nobel Peace Prize in 2006 for the promotion and application of the model. However, Yunus's approach ultimately serves U.S. economic interests more than the needs of Bangladesh's population. Policies such as land redistribution, jobs programs, and labor laws that tackle the systemic roots of poverty are anathema to the neoliberal policy prescriptions; the latter favors the promotion of entrepreneurship, privatization, deregulation, and liberalization of finance and trade instead. Microfinance may lead to endless debt traps, but at least everyone is a small business owner!

U.S. officials have called for such neoliberal "economic reforms" in Bangladesh to benefit U.S. corporations. In meetings with the Chamber of Commerce corporate lobbyists in Dhaka, U.S. officials stated that "the American private sector can help unlock Bangladesh's growth potential." They highlighted areas such as energy security, data centers, and transportation, asserting that with the right economic reforms, U.S. businesses could play a positive role in many facets of Bangladesh's economy, boosting trade and investment. This aligns with the broader U.S. agenda of promoting a market-friendly environment that caters to U.S. corporate interests while limiting the government's ability to implement policies that would more directly address the structural causes of poverty.

The International Republican Institute (IRI), a U.S. nonprofit organization founded in 1983, played a significant role in the events leading up to the fall of Sheikh Hasina's administration. The organization's stated mission is to "advance freedom and democracy worldwide" and is primarily funded by the U.S. State Department, the U.S. Agency for International Development (USAID), and the National Endowment for Democracy (NED). Board members are typically prominent members of the Republican Party and include the likes of Dan Sullivan, Tom Cotton, Lindsey Graham, Mitt Romney, and Marco Rubio.

IRI's website quotes Ronald Reagan's 1982 speech to the British Parliament in which he calls upon "freedom-loving nations to foster the infrastructure of democracy in countries that are lacking any semblance of democratic development." It was founded as one of the core institutes of the NED, itself well-known for promoting "democracy" worldwide through covert regime change operations. The IRI has been implicated in the 2004 coup d'état in Haiti against Jean-Bertrand Aristide, the first democratically elected president of Haiti who favored policies to eradicate poverty and was deeply critical of neoliberalism and U.S. interventionism. We should view both the NED and IRI alongside the CIA as the many arms of the U.S. government that bring about regime change in and destabilize targeted countries, with the two former organizations employed to mask such operations with deceptive discourse about "democracy promotion," "good governance," "authoritarianism," and the like.

An IRI [report](#) submitted to the U.S. State Department titled "Promoting Accountability, Inclusivity, and Resiliency Support Program (PAIRS)" details the IRI's activities in Bangladesh, dating from March 1, 2019, to December 31, 2020. The report summarized its activities as such:

To enhance the political participation of Bangladesh citizens and amplify anti-authoritarianism voices, IRI implemented a broad-based

social empowerment project that fostered and expanded citizen-centered, local and non-traditional forums for political engagement. IRI issued 11 advocacy grants to artists, musicians, performers or organizations that created 225 art products addressing political and social issues that were viewed nearly 400,000 times; supported three civil society organizations (CSOs) from LGBTI, Bihari and ethnic communities to train 77 activists and engage 326 citizens to develop 43 specific policy demands, which were proposed before 65 government officials; and conducted community-specific quantitative and qualitative research, including three focus group reports and the largest published survey of LGBTI people in Bangladesh.

Note the irony: the conservative U.S. politicians, including the high-ranking officials who lead the IRI, often exhibit hostility toward the LGBTI communities within the U.S. as they attempt to manipulate concerns of such communities in countries they target for destabilization and regime change.

On several occasions, the report mentions power shifts and destabilization as the program's objectives, most notably in a table mentioning "Key Activities" where the IRI details conducting interviews and identifying over 170 "democratic activists who would cooperate with IRI to destabilize Bangladesh's politics." This overt admission highlights the IRI's intent to leverage civil society actors as tools for political interference under the guise of promoting democracy. Such actions exemplify how external interventions often exploit genuine grievances within marginalized communities to further geopolitical agendas rather than addressing the root causes of systemic inequality. By co-opting cultural and social movements, the IRI not only undermines the sovereignty of the targeted nation but also risks delegitimizing the struggles of those communities by tying them to foreign interests. This strategy aligns with broader patterns of U.S.-led regime change operations, where fostering dissent and destabilization serve as precursors to achieving strategic dominance.

Bangladesh's political upheaval is emblematic of broader geopolitical struggles where local movements intersect with global interests. While the youth-led protests sought legitimate reforms, the aftermath—a Western-aligned interim government—raises questions about the true beneficiaries of this change. Yunus's leadership, shaped by the history of his collaboration with Western institutions, suggests a potential rollback of policies that sought to strengthen Bangladesh's sovereignty and align itself with the Global South.

Bangladesh's people must remain vigilant as it navigates this critical juncture. The Global South has seen similar scenarios unfold, where changes initially driven by grassroots demands are redirected to serve external powers. Bangladesh's future will depend on its ability to balance domestic aspirations with external pressures and ensure that its sovereignty and the welfare of its citizens remain a paramount concern.

Asha Zavareen is a South Asian communist organizer with the Party for Socialism and Liberation (PSL). She has helped organize local mutual aid networks and tenant unions. She is passionate about fighting for an end to death and destruction caused by imperialism and bringing about a socialist revolution. She can be contacted at asha.patel362@gmail.com

Cities Made Differently: Try Imagining Another Urban Existence

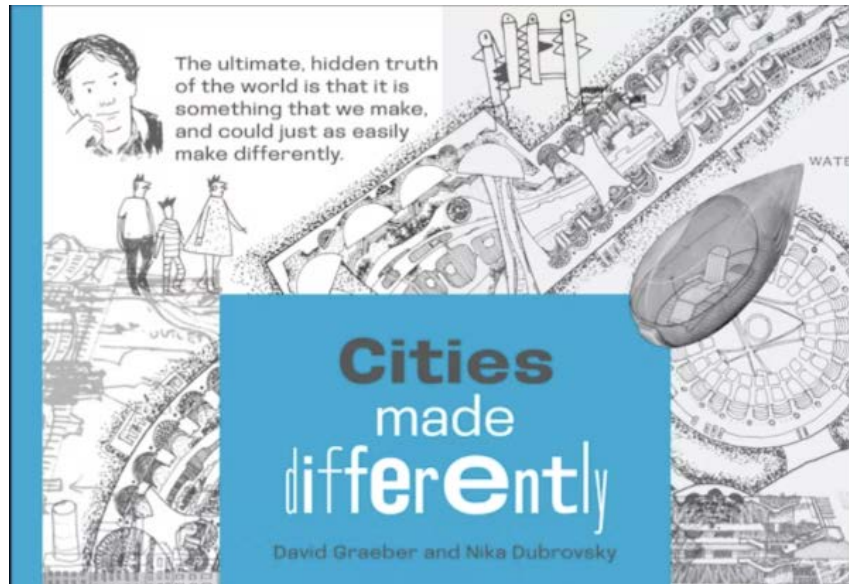
We know from history that there are many ways we can live together—let's explore the idea.

DAVID GRAEBER & NIKA DUBROVSKY

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Our first focus is [Cities Made Differently](#), exploring different ways of living together. Read and imagine four different kinds of cities taken from our book which are listed below, and continue your exploration, downloadable at [a4kids.org](#), for drawing and dreaming.



City of Greed

What if you had to live in a city whose citizens must pay not only for housing and health care but also for the air they breathe?

The dystopian novel *The Air Merchant* takes place in a secret underground factory city. Mr. Bailey, the factory owner, condenses air from the atmosphere and sells it to his fellow citizens for a profit. Eventually, the Earth's atmosphere thins, creating a

catastrophic shortage of breathable air. With the price of air increasing, fewer and fewer humans can afford to keep breathing.

When people can't pay for the air they breathe, the police throw them out of the city. Everyone lives in constant fear of suffocating, thinking only of how to earn enough money to spare their loved ones and themselves that terrible fate. The food company Nestlé is often criticized for its irresponsible use of water in India, Pakistan, and other developing countries. Captured in the documentary film *We Feed the World* (2005), former Nestlé chairman Peter Brabeck-Letmathe said:

"It's a question of whether we should privatize the normal water supply for the population. And there are two different opinions on the matter... NGOs, who bang on about declaring water a public right... That's an extreme solution. The other view says that water is a foodstuff like any other, and like any other foodstuff, it should have a market value. Personally, I believe it's better to give a foodstuff a value so that we're all aware it has its price..."

City as a Family

Imagine a city without any strangers, where everything is shared, and everyone looks after each other. There are no shops, no money, and no danger at all.

We think of the family as a group that practices "basic communism": from each according to his ability to each according to his needs. Any family is thought to be protected by bonds of kinship from the cruel laws of the outside world. Unlike businesses, rarely will a family throw out a sick child or an elderly parent because they are no longer "revenue-generating assets."

According to Roman law, which still underlies the value system of Western societies, a family was all those people living within the household of a paterfamilias or father whose authority over them was recognized as absolute. Under the protection of her father, a woman might be spared abuse from her husband, but their children, slaves, and other dependents were his to do with as he wanted.

According to early Roman law, a father was fully within his rights to whip, torture, or sell them. A father could even execute his children, provided that he found them to have committed capital crimes. With his slaves, he didn't even need that excuse.

The patriarchal family is also the model for authoritarianism. In ancient Rome, the patriarch had the right to treat his household members as property rather than as equal human beings.

The Enlightenment philosopher Jean-Jacques Rousseau believed that humankind originally lived in small bands of hunter-gatherers composed of close friends and relatives until big cities and agriculture emerged, and with them wars, greed, and exploitation.

However, archaeology shows us numerous examples of how people in different times and across different parts of the Earth lived in large metropolitan areas while managing their collective affairs on a fairly egalitarian basis. At the same time, there have always been small communities where status inequality prevailed and a privileged minority at the top benefited by exploiting the rest.

We know from our personal experience that in almost every family there are elements of both authoritarianism and baseline communism. This contradiction never fully goes away but different cultures handle it differently.

A City of Runners

The people who live in this city believe that real life is all about constant competition.

The people in a city of runners find it fascinating or even necessary to keep track of who among them is more important, who is richer, smarter, more beautiful, or more worthy. There are many ideas about how the city came to have habits like this.

One of the city's revered philosophers, Thomas Hobbes, believed that the natural state of human beings is to seek violent domination over their neighbors, and that society without the authority of the sovereign would quickly turn into a battle of all against all. Constant competition between people is thus seen as an enjoyable game as compared to real war, which is always lurking around the corner.

Naturally, in cities like this, there must be some who are poor, ugly, and unhappy. Just as in some children's games, there are winners and losers.

People living in the city of runners foster an admiration for winning in their kids, and an ambition to surpass their peers in all areas. Children in the city of runners have no interest in learning together, sharing, or mutual aid. Helping someone pass an exam is considered "cheating" and is strictly punished. All their lives, adults are engaged in constant competition over beauty, skill, and wealth.

Runners believe that people who live differently from them and who refuse to play their games simply choose to be losers. During the 1968 student unrest in Western countries, some disaffected young people abandoned the big cities for the "sleepy" provinces where they created autonomous settlements, many of which still exist today.

Underground City

Living in an underground city could be safe and convenient. Without weather, there's no risk of storms. And no trees mean no forest fires.

Underground cities have been around practically forever. The city of Derinkuyu in the Turkish province of Cappadocia, for example, was built between 2000 and 1000 BCE. The landscape of volcanic tuff—a unique soft stone—could be hollowed out without requiring complex tools, making room to house 20,000 people. The underground city boasted a stable, corrals, churches, schools, canteens, bakeries, barns, wine cellars, and workshops. The intricate system of tunnels connecting it all together meant that intruders would not know their way around and quickly get lost.

Tunnels are found underneath many cities. Rome is famous for its catacombs, and at one time subterranean burial chambers were commonplace. These days, tunnels tend to be for underground trains called subways. In Beijing, the residents became so fearful of nuclear war that they built an entire bunker city, with 30 kilometers of tunnels connecting underground houses, schools, hospitals, shops, libraries, theaters, and factories. There's even an underground roller skating rink!

Mexico City has not gone as far as to build an entire city underground, but architect Esteban Suarez is planning an underground apartment building. And what a building it will be! Piercing the center of the Mexican capital with its tip will be a

65-story pyramid—no wonder they call it the earthscraper. The glass-enclosed area above the surface will be for recreation and outdoor concerts.

Underground, the building will be heated and powered with geothermal energy, making the pyramid energy self-sufficient. It's not easy building downward into the earth, but building underground won't disrupt the historical landscape of the city. And it evades the city's building codes restricting the height of structures to eight floors.

Mirny, a town in the Russian far north, has its eye on an abandoned diamond mine as the site for an underground city. There are no more diamonds to be found, but its abandonment threatens neighboring villages with cave-ins and landslides. Moscow architect Nikolai Lyutovsky has proposed a solution: building a strong concrete skeleton inside the quarry to strengthen its walls while covering its top with a transparent dome, resulting in an underground eco-city fit for 10,000 people.

Located in the Yakutia Republic, the town has a harsh arctic climate with temperatures reaching as low as -60 degrees Celsius in the winter. But underground, the temperature never falls below zero. The quarry would thus be good for both people and plants. Its architects have allocated most of the city's inner space to vertical farms. Farms for food production, technical laboratories, factories, and research centers are located underground and, aboveground, there will be play centers and schools. Moving between the underground and the surface is quick and easy.

Going underground to avoid possible misfortunes—might seem like a good idea, but there's a catch: if you don't like the rules of your community, it's tough to get out. How important is it to be able to easily leave one community whose rules no longer suit you and join a different one?

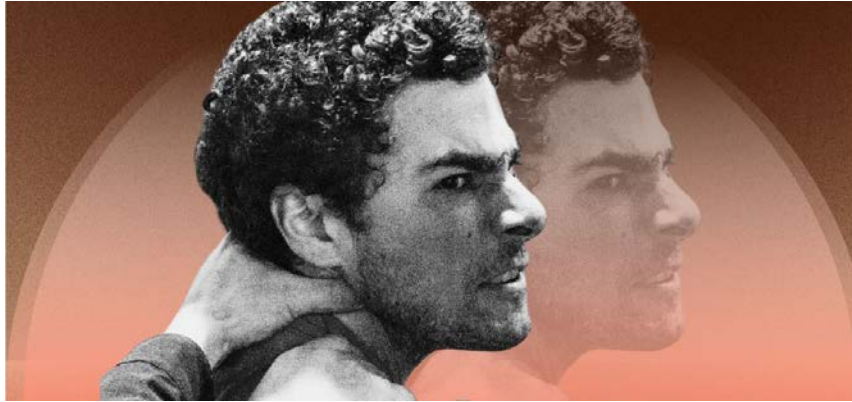
David Graeber was an anthropologist and activist and is a [bestselling author](#).

Nika Dubrovsky is an artist, writer, and founder of the [David Graeber Institute](#) and the Museum of Care

This is an excerpt adapted from Nika Dubrovsky and David Graeber's [Cities Made Differently](#) (MIT Press, 2024, all rights reserved). It is distributed in partnership with [Human Bridges](#) and first appeared on [ZNetwork](#) on November 22, 2024.

Social Murder, Social Rage

VERSO BOOKS



Exploitation, neglect, deprivation, death. These are not accidents of fate but the calculated outcomes of a system that prioritizes profit over human life. Friedrich Engels called it “social murder,” a term that cuts to the heart of capitalism’s hidden violence. It is murder disguised as policy, hidden behind the cold machinery of economic necessity, and suffered quietly by those whose lives are deemed expendable.

As Engels wrote in *The Condition of the Working Class in England* in 1845:

“When one individual inflicts bodily injury upon another such that death results, we call the deed manslaughter; when the assailant knew in advance that the injury would be fatal, we call his deed murder. But when society places hundreds of proletarians in such a position that they inevitably meet a too early and an unnatural death, one which is quite as much a death by violence as that by the sword or bullet; when it deprives thousands of the necessities of life, places them under conditions in which they cannot live—forces them, through the strong arm of the law, to remain in such conditions until that death ensues which is the inevitable consequence—knows that these thousands of victims must perish, and yet permits these conditions to remain, its deed is murder just as surely as the deed of the single individual; disguised, malicious murder, murder against which none can defend himself, which does not seem what it is, because no man sees the murderer, because the death of the victim seems a natural one, since the offence is more one of omission than of commission. But murder it remains.”

Following the brazen shooting of United Healthcare CEO Brian Thompson, Luigi Mangione has been arrested and charged with murder. His handwritten manifesto reads like a contemporary echo of Engels’ description of “social murder,” this

time carried out by health insurance executives, shareholders, and the rapacious profit motive that animates them.

Mangione has become an overnight hero after his arrest, channeling the rage of millions of Americans left to rot by their for-profit healthcare system. Bipartisan lines have blurred—if only briefly—as people across the political spectrum cheer ‘Free Luigi’ and pray for his escape. It’s no accident that their would-be revolutionary is an athletic and strikingly attractive 26-year-old, his body wrecked by the pain of a botched spinal surgery. Who better to embody the profound desperation of loss than a man who seemed to have it all, only to lose everything anyway?

A handsome 26-year-old computer engineer with metal rods through his spine and, allegedly, a 3-D printed plastic pistol has become the face of a movement—or at least a moment of catharsis—quickly inspiring memes, merchandise, and even a secular prayer candle. But the backdrop to this tech-noir thriller, unfolding over mass media, is the stark reality that in America, one’s life and health are held hostage by capitalism, ransomed back through deductibles, copays, premiums, and the relentless financialization of every aspect of our well-being. If Engels had foreseen a future where algorithms dictate who lives, who dies, who suffers, or who watches a loved one fade in agony, we might not have believed him.

And yet here we are, with our loved ones and livelihoods reduced to metrics on a balance sheet. Social murder might have found more sophisticated methods, but its victims remain the same. It’s little wonder that such raw acts of vigilantism resonate so deeply, even if their political consequences remain uncertain. This rage is visceral in the truest sense of the word.

Various outlets are accusing the Left of celebrating the death of a husband and father at the hands of a disaffected young man. It is true that Left intellectuals have long grappled with the ethics of violence, the immorality of for-profit industries like healthcare, the dynamics of power and oppression, and the complexities of both violent and non-violent resistance. But this issue—like all meaningful ones—is not partisan. If there’s an audience with an appetite for blood it was created by the very industry and elites who now condemn it. Our ability to experience joy and dignity in our bodies is a fundamental and universal concern. The barbarity of capitalism, which has disfigured this basic human right, is felt by every American, no matter what they recite from a teleprompter.

Editor’s Note: This commentary [first appeared as a blog post at Verso Books on 13 September 2024.](#)

California Law Mandates Teaching About State's Genocide of Native Americans

GARY OLSON

From the time the Europeans arrived on American shores, the U.S. government authorized more than 1,500 wars and attacks on Indigenous people, and after the “Indian wars” in the late 19th century, of the estimated 10 million to 15 million native peoples, fewer than 238,000 remained. In the past, I’ve written about these efforts in the Great Plains and upper Midwest. I’m now spending some time in Santa Barbara, California, which has prompted my looking into that state’s role in the great American genocide. The Santa Barbara region was inhabited by Chumash people for at least 11,000 years and before the European invaders arrived the population was some 18,000. By 1900 it had declined to less than 500 and today it’s leveled off at about 5,000.

A new California law, which takes effect on January 1, 2025, requires that public schools begin teaching about the state’s treatment of Native Americans. The State Department of Education must consult with tribes when updating the social studies curriculum and several tribes are advocating the inclusion of material contained in UCLA professor Benjamin Madley’s book, *An American Genocide: The United States and the California Indian Catastrophe, 1846–1873*. This is the first comprehensive account of the state-sanctioned murder of California’s Native People. Madley documents how state and federal governments employed their legitimizing authority for the genocide and Congress financially underwrote California’s extinction campaign.

The new legislation was set in motion five years ago when California Gov. Gavin Newsom publicly apologized for the “war of extermination” pronounced by Peter Burnett, the state’s first governor in 1851. Newsom said that at the time, state law required that Native Americans be removed from their land, children separated from their families, native people stripped of their language and culture, and a system of indentured servitude was begun. Under Gov. Burnett, California’s Indigenous population was reduced by 80 percent.

In 1846, U.S. troops took control of California from Mexico, and in 1848, the Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo ended the war with Mexico and ceded California and its other northern territories for 15 million dollars. On January 6, 1851, the new governor of California said the following about the “Indians” in his inaugural address: “That war of extermination will continue to be waged between the races until the Indian is extinct. While we cannot anticipate this result with painful regret, the inevitable destruction of a race is beyond the power of the wisdom of man to avert.” California Senator John B. Weller declared of the Indians, “Humanity may forbid, but the interests of the white man demand their extinction.” This “myth of inevitable extinction” fueled the ideology that Indians were destined to vanish, that it was simply their fate and unstoppable.

And in case there remains any doubt that this was not official policy, we know that the men who “killed thousands of Indians from the 1840s to the 1870s were paid by the state of California and the federal government...they filed expenses and were reimbursed.” (Tom Fuller, “Hastings Law Grapples with the Founder’s Involvement with Native Massacres,” *NYTimes*, updated November 4, 2021). It should be noted that with the outbreak of the Civil War, California sent 15,725 volunteers to serve in the Union Army. However, there were so many volunteers that enough remained at home to serve as the primary agent of the killing machine. Further, during the Civil War, the Union government’s treasury was running perilously low, but Congress still allotted major funding to the California Volunteers for their Indian-hunting operation. Madley calculates that at the end of the Civil War, only 34,000 Indians remained from 150,000 in 1845. Limited attacks continued until 1871 when it was beginning to be hard to find any more Indians left to kill. The decline was caused by killings, disease, starvation, and massacres. Madley estimates that the “state spent 1.7 million—a staggering sum in its day—to murder some 16,000 people.”

My hope (perhaps a fantasy) is that Indian and non-Indian public-school kids in California will be deprogrammed and learn that genocide, like slavery, was part of the inherent capitalist logic of dispossession. Will they be exposed to the truth that there exists a glaring contemporary parallel to this history in Israel’s “plausible genocide” (ICJ) in Gaza and the future ethnic cleansing of the West Bank? Young Native Americans understand that they are the descendants of genocide as the banner flown by the Oglala Lakota’s Youth Council in South Dakota reads, “From Pine Ridge to Palestine.” Will school children learn, as Middle East Eye’s Jonathan Cook points out, that Israel is now finishing the job it began in 1948? At least as important, will they be encouraged to understand that, as in the 1840-1871 period in California, the U.S. government is not only backing this modern-day war of extermination but its actions are wholly consonant with the objective of U.S. imperialism in its efforts to maintain America’s global empire? Will they learn that both Israel and the United States were settler-colonial state projects and not as the official narratives proclaim, “nations of immigrants.”

Gary Olson is Professor Emeritus of Political Science at Moravian University in Bethlehem, PA; his books include U.S. Foreign Policy and the Third World Peasant (1974), The Other Europe (1977), How the World Works (1981) and Empathy Imperiled: Capitalism, Culture and the Brain (2013).

How Neoliberalism Has Wielded ‘Corruption’ to Privatize Life in Africa

GRIEVE CHELWA

In Africa, the leading forces of capitalism have ruthlessly wielded a neoliberal conception of corruption to undermine states’ sovereignty and open the continent to plunder at the hands of Western multinational corporations.

In the years following the fall of the Soviet Union, the word ‘corruption’ increasingly began to appear in the reports of multilateral agencies and non-governmental organizations. These reports argued that corruption is rooted in the regulatory function of states, which control large-scale development projects and whose officials oversee the delivery of licenses and permits; if the regulatory function of states could be minimized, many of these reports argued, corruption would be less pervasive. This kind of anti-corruption discourse fits neatly within the neoliberal drive to shrink states’ regulatory apparatuses, deregulate and privatize economic activity, and promote the idea that the freedom of the market’s invisible hand would create a moral foundation for society.

Yet, none of these reports—including those from the World Bank and Transparency International—offered a clear definition of corruption. In *The Anti-Corruption Plain Language Guide* (2009), Transparency International defined corruption as ‘the abuse of entrusted power for private gain.’ Three years later, the World Bank described corruption as ‘the abuse of public office for private gain.’ These definitions are similar, and they continue to be reproduced in reports from multilateral organizations and in academic scholarship. The key word here is ‘abuse,’ and the main implication is that someone in the public sector entrusted with power or public office abuses their role for private gain, such as through bribery, nepotism, extortion, and embezzlement. This orientation argues that if the state were smaller or more disciplined, there would be little to no corruption in society. Even though the non-governmental organization Transparency International added a concern about private sector corruption in 2010, this addition has been marginal to the overall focus on public sector corruption.

The epicenter of this argument has been the African continent, where the idea of ‘corruption’—meaning corruption of the state—has effectively been used to diminish the state’s regulatory functions and reduce the number of state employees. It is important to note that while 21% of the European workforce, on average, is employed in the public sector, that number is a mere 2.38% in Mali, 3.6% in Nigeria, and 6.7% in Zambia, which in turn limits these states’ capacity to manage and regulate large multinational corporations on the African continent.

Furthermore, over the course of the 1990s and the 2000s, the International Monetary Fund (IMF) fought to reduce public-sector employees’ salaries, which certainly increases the likelihood of bribery. The IMF outlined this approach in its 1991

Public Expenditure Handbook, which makes reducing the wage bill for public-sector workers a central part of its agenda.

In neoliberal literature, corruption primarily takes the form of bribery, extortion, and embezzlement—all of which refer principally to public sector corruption—while omitting concepts such as transfer mispricing, trade mis-invoicing, accounting irregularities, financial mismanagement, and tax avoidance—all of which are essential elements of multinational corporations’ accounting practices.

There are a range of socio-psychological reasons for corruption, the most referenced one being greed. But greed is not a transhistorical concept or emotion; rather, it is shaped by the social formation in which it is allowed to grow. Capitalism has a special relationship to greed since it fosters the ‘animal spirits’ (as the economist John Maynard Keynes put it) to reduce all human life to commodities and to centralize the profit motive as the economic motor.

Yet, older forms of morality that are eager to set aside hypocrisy and overcome the dominion of money prevail in social consciousness across the world. This dossier is anchored in the popular sentiment against corruption in society, driven largely not by petty bribery but by industrial-scale corruption by private capital. The Malaysian sociologist Syed Hussein Alatas called this ‘tidal corruption’: the corruption that ‘floods the entire state apparatus involving those at the center of power. Like the tide, it rises to cover wider areas and immerse the surrounding vegetation.’ This dossier is not a defense of corruption; on the contrary, it argues for an understanding of corruption that is not rooted solely in the public sector but that appreciates the tidal corruption set in motion by the leading forces of capitalism. It focuses on the African continent because that is where agencies such as the IMF and the World Bank have most effectively wielded the idea of ‘corruption’ to undermine states’ sovereignty and subjugate the countries of the Global South to the extraordinary power of multinational corporations, particularly in the mining sector.

Part 1: The Neoliberal Corruption Industry

In 1993, Peter Eigen, a German lawyer who worked at the World Bank in the legal department, registered an association in Germany called Transparency International. Eigen worked with Michael Wiehen (formerly of the World Bank) and Hans-jörg Elshorst (formerly of the German Agency for Technical Cooperation) to establish Transparency International in German business and government circles as a legitimate organization. Before going forward to discipline countries of the Global South, the association had to ensure that European states had built their own legitimacy regarding corruption. That is why they lobbied the governments of France and Germany to stop the policy of what, in Germany, is called *Schmiergeld* (bribe money); these countries not only allowed bribes to be paid in foreign jurisdictions but then permitted companies to deduct these payments from tax obligations. This lobbying resulted in the passage of the 1999 Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD) Convention on Combating the Bribery of Foreign Public Officials in International Business Transactions. By passing this convention, European officials and their counterparts in North America created a framework about corruption through which to adopt a morally superior position over governments in the

Global South. In 1997, Matthew Parris, a conservative South African-born member of the British Parliament, said, 'Corruption has become an African epidemic. It is impossible to overstate the poisoning of human relations and the paralyzing of initiative that corruption on the African scale brings.' This phrase—on the African scale—defines an attitude toward corruption that embodies both the long colonial history of theft and the neocolonial present of corporate malfeasance on the continent.

Yet those who moralize about African corruption have little to say when it comes to the criminality of corporate corruption. Take, for example, the German-South African retail giant Steinhoff International (1964–2023). In 2015, German officials raided the offices of Steinhoff Europe Group Services as part of an investigation into accounting fraud. As the scandal became too big to contain, with new investigations by contracted firms such as PriceWaterhouseCoopers, and with Steinhoff's senior management forced to resign, the South African parliament opened its own investigation of the firm, which found that businesses such as Steinhoff rely upon public funds for their investments, including—in the case of South Africa—the Public Investment Corporation. These public funds lost billions in Steinhoff's eventual collapse. In 2019, South Africa's Financial Sector Conduct Authority imposed an administrative fine of ZAR 1.5 billion (US \$95 million) on the company for false, misleading, or deceptive statements to the market. This fine was later reduced to ZAR 53 million (US \$3.4 million), a minuscule amount compared to the approximately ZAR 124.9 billion (US \$6.9 billion) involved in fictitious or irregular transactions that substantially inflated Steinhoff's profits and assets between 2009 and 2017. In the service of 'investor-friendly policies', these scandals are either underreported or treated as the exception rather than the rule. Yet this is a familiar story, from the accounting debacles at Enron Corporation (2001) and Arthur Andersen (2002)—which led to the largest known case of corporate fraud in history—to the faked emissions scandal at Volkswagen (2015).

Before Transparency

In the period of decolonization and then of the formation of post-colonial states, Western-driven modernization theory argued that corruption was not a 'poison' but an asset that helped shape the relationship between the ruling class and the state apparatus. Drawing from the experience of the United States, Robert K. Merton's *Social Theory and Social Structure* (1949) provided the basis for this line of argument: that corruption made the relationship between state officials and the ruling class more intimate. In the 1960s, a range of influential scholars published important articles based on fieldwork in Africa and Asia to substantiate the claim that corruption 'humanizes government,' as Edward Shils wrote in 1960. Indeed, in his classic work *Political Order in Changing Societies* (1968), Samuel Huntington argued that corruption (or what he defined as 'patronage from above') in Africa, Asia, and Latin America had contributed to the creation of 'the most effective political parties and most stable political systems.' In this Western modernization literature, which dominated the worldview of multilateral institutions, corruption was treated as an utterly normal—even beneficial—form of economic interaction.

Modernization theory played a considerable role in the new post-colonial states, but it was not the only approach to economic development. In 1955, the Bandung Final Communiqué made it clear that the most predatory aspect of the world economy's neocolonial structure was the role of transnational corporations (TNCs), as they were known then (later called multinational corporations, or MNCs). Many of these TNCs, which emerged during the colonial era, had built up their capital stock through colonial theft and structured world economic relations to gain privileged access to raw materials in the former colonies as well as captive markets to which to export their expensive finished products. That is why the new post-colonial states centered the role of TNCs as they developed the platform of the New International Economic Order (NIEO): if these states were to establish sovereignty over their own territories, they had to reduce the power of TNCs either by regulation or restriction. Since many of these states lacked the capacity to develop an in-depth analysis of how these firms were organized or how they managed their financial transactions, they urged the UN Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD) and other United Nations bodies to do so. In 1974, the UN Centre for Transnational Corporations (UNCTC) was created for this purpose and began to build a database on the major TNCs' operations in order to understand what was seen as the institutionalization of corruption through novel maneuvers of accounting.

At the same time, the post-colonial states understood the grave limitations they had inherited from their old colonial masters all too well, such as a hierarchical state apparatus designed to terrorize the colonized population and a bureaucracy that had been trained to serve the ends of colonialism, not the people. With the departure of the colonial bureaucrats, the now independent states had to train almost an entirely new administration, many of whose cadre came from impoverished or near-impoorished backgrounds (material conditions that increased the temptation to accept bribes). These states opened public administration institutes to develop the capacity of their new employees and to encourage them to work with the spirit of the national liberation struggles that had won them independence. Each state's attitude towards public administration varied based on its class politics: in states with a more landlord-bourgeois character, the public administration institutes inherited the old colonial forms of bureaucracy without much revision, whereas states with a higher socialist character (such as China and Vietnam) emphasized combating the forms of hierarchy amongst state officials. In Vietnam, for instance, Ho Chi Minh called upon the new workers to lead by example rather than corrupt society with bribery and extortion (*Thi đua là yêu nước, yêu nước thì phải thi đua*, Ho Chi Minh said: 'emulation is patriotism; patriots must emulate'). Since the material conditions to build a new kind of state simply did not exist, modern training and social pressure became the primary avenues through which to inculcate new values against a backdrop of low salaries and great temptations (the 'creation of a new man', as Ernesto 'Che' Guevara wrote). Yet, in the era 'before transparency', under pressure from TNCs and from Western modernization theory which justified bribery, post-colonial governments struggled to produce new state values.

The Age of Transparency

In the 1990s, a new argument emerged from the Western academy and multilateral organizations controlled by Western governments. This new theory, which moved from modernization to neoliberal theory, suggested that the states in the Global South were the locus of corruption, that a smaller state would largely solve the problem, and that more pressure must be placed on these states in order to 'discipline' them. The idea that TNCs—now MNCs (multinational corporations)—could be corrupt completely vanished in this theory.

In 1992, under pressure from the US government, the UNCTC was integrated into UNCTAD, where its mandate was radically transformed. Instead of being a watchdog of these large corporations, the UNCTC put its resources toward helping MNCs enter southern markets. There was no more interest in producing a TNC Code of Conduct, the skeleton of which was relegated to a languishing draft from 1983 that is raised every few years and thereafter ignored in special sessions. In other words, the UNCTC became largely moot. What is truly remarkable is that the UNCTC and its code of conduct were sidelined by the West just when UNCTAD showed that 80% of global trade (in terms of gross exports) was linked to the international production networks of these mega-corporations that operated across national boundaries and that the market was becoming increasingly concentrated around these firms. That is largely why multilateral agencies make no mention of the private sector in their definition of corruption, which they describe as merely the 'abuse of public office for private gain.'

In 1995, in place of the UNCTC's TNC Code of Conduct, Transparency International released its annual Corruption Perceptions Index (CPI). The CPI was measured by a group of 'experts' (often private businessmen) who offered their subjective assessment of public sector corruption in various countries. Even when the CPI redefined corruption in 2010 as 'the abuse of entrusted power for private gain, encompassing practices in both the public and private sectors', it still ranked countries based on the perception of corruption in the public sector. The underlying neoliberal theory here is that corruption in the public sector corrodes the quality of investments in public goods, as corrupt officials seek to increase the volume of investments in order to increase bribes without considering how those investments align with broader national development goals. According to this theory, the correct course is more privatization and less government oversight; its proposal for 'transparency' is merely to eviscerate regulatory state apparatuses and exaggerate the private sector's ability to profit from public goods.

Under pressure from Transparency International and allied Western governments, the United Nations General Assembly adopted the UN Convention Against Corruption in 2003, which was replicated in the 2003 African Union Convention on Preventing and Combating Corruption. The UN and African Union (AU) treaties do not explicitly define corruption; rather, they make a list of offenses that they suggest should be criminalized, which overwhelmingly focuses on the public sector (such as bribery of public officials). The UN convention, AU convention, and Transparency International's CPI treat various types of theft as perfectly legal, including the legal theft of surplus value from workers, the illegal deductions of fines and fees used to

penalize workers, and corruption legalized by accountants. By turning a blind eye to corporate corruption and focusing, instead, on bribes of public officials, these entities normalize the structured criminality of capitalism. Furthermore, the Western-driven UN Convention and the Western-based NGO (Transparency International) that have taken charge of this discourse of corruption have made it appear as though the West has transcended corruption, and that corruption is primarily a problem in the Global South. This narrative exculpates the Western-based MNCs from blame and erases the long anti-corruption struggles in the Global South, a rich ethical tradition that is rooted both in religion and in common sense.

Meanwhile, the world of accounting has developed a new form of theft called 'sustainability reporting,' which is emblematic of a broader trend that seeks ways to hide money from tax authorities and legalize corruption. This form of greenwashing allows accounting firms to disclose what they are doing to incorporate environmental, social, and governance (ESG) factors in order to discount their taxable income, and in so doing, often providing false or misleading claims about the environmental benefits of a product, service, or investment. Furthermore, these accounting practices are not obligated to produce or follow a proper environmental assessment, nor are they concerned about the displacement of residents from an area of operation, degradation of ecosystems, misuse of agricultural land, consumption of fossil fuel energy, or harsh exploitation of labor. Despite rampant abuse by MNCs—the plastic pollution generated by Coca-Cola's Africa branch; logging in Norwegian-owned Green Resources Mozambique, Tanzania, and Uganda; and wildly unethical harvesting of 'ethical diamonds' by De Beers, to name a few—accounting firms are allowed to investigate themselves and are absolved from accusations of corruption for this type of behavior, which falls far outside the neoliberal understanding of corruption.

(Editor's Note: We have skipped Part 2 of this Dossier)

Part 3: Five Ways to Make Money from Africa

In his 1963 book *Africa Must Unite*, Ghana's first President Kwame Nkrumah wrote, 'We have here, in Africa, everything necessary to become a powerful, modern, industrialized continent. United Nations investigators have recently shown that Africa, far from having inadequate resources, is probably better equipped for industrialization than almost any other region in the world'. Nkrumah was referring to the United Nations' Special Study on Economic Conditions and Development, Non-Self-Governing Territories (1958), which detailed the continent's immense natural resources. 'The true explanation for the slowness of industrial development in Africa,' Nkrumah wrote, 'lies in the policies of the colonial period. Practically all our natural resources, not to mention trade, shipping, banking, building, and so on, fell into, and have remained in, the hands of foreigners seeking to enrich alien investors and to hold back local economic initiative.'

How exactly do alien investors go about making money from 'everything necessary' for Africa's sovereign development? We decided to put together a five-point guide that begins to answer that question.

Working with the IMF, World Bank, and World Trade Organization to encourage (i.e., coerce) African governments to implement 'investor-friendly' policies. By 'investor-friendly policies,' we mean the kinds of policies that make it easy to bring capital into Africa and use that capital to extract as much wealth as possible from the continent. Examples of such policies include privatizing vital social services (health and education are key); enacting tax incentives that make it possible for investors to pay zero taxes; eliminating labor rights so that workers can be exploited as much as possible; and liberalizing the host country's capital account, which makes it easy to extract all the profits made in Africa.

Investing in the extractives sector, but not in manufacturing. The trick is to invest in those sectors that make it easy to make a quick buck while hiding behind a veil of opacity. There is no better sector to do this than extractives in Africa, whether drilling oil in Angola, collecting coltan in the Congo, or capturing natural gas in Mozambique. The sites of extraction in this sector are often in enclaves far away from capital cities and, therefore, away from the prying eyes of regulators and the citizenry, thus providing the necessary cover to extract as many resources as possible. Furthermore, investing in extractives rather than manufacturing promises the perpetual underdevelopment of Africa and, therefore, guarantees that the continent will forever be vulnerable to extractive capital—an investment that just keeps giving.

Engaging in transfer pricing. Transfer pricing is a time-tested technique developed by MNCs to expatriate as much profit as possible from the Global South. The subsidiary company in Africa 'sells' its products to the so-called parent company in the West, which subsequently sells the product to the ultimate beneficiary and, therefore, pockets the profits in the West. For example, a Swiss-owned mining operation in the Congo sells its cobalt to its parent company in Switzerland for a price that is nearly zero; the Swiss company then sells the cobalt to the ultimate buyer located at an electric car company in the US at the true value of the cobalt. The general idea with transfer pricing is to pay as little taxes as possible in Africa while booking the profits in the West and paying moderate taxes there.

Exaggerating production costs. Remember that since corporate taxes are levied on profits, anything that fictitiously reduces profits reported in Africa also limits the taxes that the corporation is obliged to pay. The example of transfer pricing is one way to reduce the profits reported in Africa. Another trick is to exaggerate costs incurred on the continent in ways that the authorities cannot verify. For example, a consulting company, located in the West, can provide expensive 'consulting services' to an African operation in a way that limits the profits in Africa and shifts them to the West. Another cost exaggeration gimmick is to grant a non-existent loan to an African subsidiary: interest payments on this fake loan serve to exaggerate production costs in Africa and, therefore, limit profits that must be reported there, instead shifting them to the West.

Hiring one of the Big Four accounting firms. The Big Four accounting firms—all British—are Deloitte, PriceWaterhouseCoopers, Ernst & Young, and Klynveld Peat Marwick Goerdeler. Their stamp of approval is golden, and their audited reports are treated as legal documents. Instead of using information barriers (so-called 'ethical walls') as they were intended—to ensure the independence and

objectivity of the tax advice, consulting services, and auditing—these firms obscure the fact that, often, the same firm provides consulting services while also auditing the hiring company's books—including auditing these consulting services. For instance, a firm proposes an operational optimization plan or aggressive tax planning, and that same firm is the 'independent auditor' that oversees this plan and then issues an allegedly unbiased opinion that the financial statements are fair. Due to the reduction of state capacity, many African governments now rely upon the reports of accounting firms as uncontested statements of the truth about the operations of MNCs. The hefty fees demanded by the Big Four are very much worth the investment for MNCs, given the hundreds of billions of dollars that they save in taxes.

These five points allow MNCs to make off with Africa's wealth while ensuring that the continent remains underdeveloped, and yet they are conceptualized as smart business strategies rather than a form of corruption or theft. These actions are legitimized by the hegemonic discourse of corruption, which has taken a decisively neoliberal direction that seeks to dismantle state regulation and protect MNCs. Actual corruption—which manifests both in the corruption of MNCs and the petty corruption of public officials—must be tackled head-on, indeed with a clarity that does not exist at present.

Will there ever be an AU Convention on Corporate Corruption?

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Editor's Note: This essay is excerpted from [Dossier No 82](#) of the Tricontinental Institute for Social Research, 26 Nov. 2024. The dossier was researched and written under the leadership of Professor Grieve Chelwa of The Africa Institute, Global Studies University, through Tricontinental Pan Africa.

[Notes for this piece are available online.](#)

[thetricontinental.org/dossier-how-neoliberalism-has-wielded-corruption-to-privatise-africa]

The Language of Grief

Poetry on Palestine, longing, and love

AHMAD IBSAIS

I spoke your name to the dunes,
 their silence a mirror to my grief.
 Each grain of sand—
 a word I never said,
 a touch I never offered.
 How vast is the desert of longing,
 how endless its horizon.
 No shadow falls here but yours,
 no wind moves but to echo
 the sound of your absence.
 Come back,
 and I will pour oceans into your palms,
 spill my breath to unbury the stars
 hidden in the hollow of your leaving.
 What is love but a wound
 that refuses to heal?

Your absence sits in my chest
 like a bird with broken wings,
 beating against the cage of my ribs.
 Each flutter a reminder
 that flight is no longer possible.
 I lit candles for you in the garden,
 but the wind came.
 It always comes, doesn't it?
 Stealing light,
 stealing warmth.

You once said love is eternal.
 But I wonder—
 is it the bloom or the ash that lingers?
 The warmth of a touch,
 or the cold ache it leaves behind?

Grief speaks in a tongue I have learned too well,
 a tongue heavy with loss,
 its alphabet carved from olive pits and bullet casings.
 It recites the names of hills that bleed into the sea,
 of streets where shadows dance beneath broken lanterns.
 Who will teach me another language—
 one where the trees do not weep
 and the earth does not swallow the voices of children?
 Oh, Palestine, your rivers run backwards,
 your fields bloom with ashes instead of wheat.
 I hold your soil in my palm and feel the weight of exile,
 its scent sharper than jasmine,
 its silence louder than a call to prayer.
 Grief writes my name beside yours
 in the book of the forgotten,
 but I refuse to be erased.
 Even if my voice cracks, I will speak you into existence
 until the dawn remembers where it belongs.

Ahmad Ibsais writes on politics, news, and culture in his Substack [State of Siege](#), focusing on Palestine, the Middle East, and Western colonialism across the world. He shared this poem on November 24, 2024.

Einstein Opposed Zionist Colonization... and Predicted the Current Catastrophe

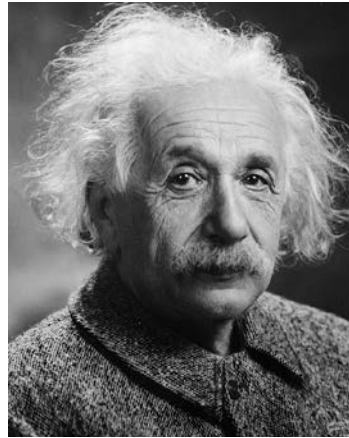
[ROBIN PHILPOT](#)

A few weeks before the creation of the State of Israel, Shepard Rifkin, executive director of the Stern Group, requested that representatives of the group meet with Albert Einstein in the United States, “the greatest Jewish figure of the time” according to I.F. Stone. Einstein’s response was unequivocal:

“When a real and final catastrophe should befall us in Palestine the first responsible for it would be the British and the second responsible for it the Terrorist organizations built up from our own ranks. I am not willing to see anybody associated with those misled and criminal people.”

To grasp Einstein’s prescience, one need only replace “the British” with “the Americans” and “terrorist organizations” such as the Stern Group and the Irgun group with the Netanyahu government, the political descendants of the leaders of these groups, Menachem Begin and Yitzhak Shamir.

Einstein said that his “life was divided between equations and politics.” Yet, among his biographers—there are hundreds of them—and in the mainstream media, his extensive political writings on Israel and Zionism have been, at best, swept under the rug. At worst, completely distorted making him a supporter of the State of Israel.



[Source: en.wikipedia.org]

American Friends of the Fighters
for the Freedom of Israel
149 Second Ave.
New York 3, N.Y.

Dear Sir:

When a real and final catastrophe should befall us in Palestine the first responsible for it would be the British and the second responsible for it the Terrorist organizations built up from our own ranks.

I am not willing to see anybody associated with those misled and criminal people.

Sincerely yours,
A. Einstein.

[Source: reddit.com]

That is until the late Fred Jerome sought them out, found them, had them translated, mostly from German, and published them in the book [Einstein on Israel and Zionism](#).

Unfortunately, the first edition of this book, published by a New York publishing house, had a very small print run, was never promoted or made into an e-book, and sold out in no time, the publisher having bowed to enormous pressure from the Zionists. That is why Baraka Books has published a new edition with the agreement of Jocelyn Jerome, the author’s widow.

It was in Germany in the 1920s, a time of rampant antisemitism when the theory of relativity was attacked as “Jewish science,” that Einstein was drawn to the Zionist movement. It was not until 1914, when he arrived in Germany, that he “discovered for the first time that he was a Jew,” a discovery he attributed more to “Gentiles than Jews.” Before that, he had seen himself as a member of the human species.

He called himself a “cultural Zionist,” but as early as 1921 Kurt Blumenfeld, a Zionist activist sent to recruit Einstein, warned Chaim Weizmann, the future president of Israel, about the great scientist:

“Einstein, as you know, is no Zionist, and I ask you not to try to make him a Zionist or to try to attach him to our organization...Einstein, who leans to socialism, feels very involved with the cause of Jewish labor and Jewish workers...I heard...that you expect Einstein to give speeches. Please be quite careful with that. Einstein...often says things out of naïveté which are unwelcome by us.”

Apart from Einstein’s supposed naïveté, Blumenfeld could not have said it better. Einstein would be a constant obstacle to the Zionist project of colonization of Palestine and the creation of the State of Israel until his death in 1955.

Here are some examples of the positions he took.

His exchanges with Chaim Weizmann, the future president of Israel, illustrate how important Einstein was to the Zionists, but more importantly how his views differed from theirs. In a letter to Weizmann on November 25, 1929, he wrote:

“If we are not able to find a way to honest cooperation and honest pacts with the Arabs, then we have learned nothing during our two thousand years of suffering, and deserve the fate which will befall us.”

The idea of “the fate which will befall us” recurs often. In 1929, he seems to have already foreseen that the State of Israel the Zionists dreamed of creating without “honest cooperation and honest pacts” with their Palestinian neighbors would become what it is today, namely the most dangerous place in the world for Jews to live.

A few weeks later, on December 14, 1929, he wrote to Selig Brodetsky of the Zionist Organization in London, “I’m happy that we have no power. If national pig-headedness proves strong enough, then we will knock our brains out as we deserve.”

Furthermore, Leon Simon, one of his early editors and translators, wrote:

“There is in Professor Einstein’s nationalism no room for any kind of aggressiveness or chauvinism. For him the domination of Jew over Arab in Palestine, or the perpetuation of a state of mutual hostility between the two peoples, would mean the failure of Zionism.”

Unlike the vast majority of Zionists, Einstein's support for a possible "Jewish homeland"—not a state—was not limited to Palestine. There was nothing religious in his commitment. Some Zionists advocated the establishment of such a homeland in China, Peru, or Birobidjan in the Soviet Union, but in full agreement with the state authorities and the populations in each case.

Einstein supported these steps. For example, on the Jewish homeland of Birobidjan in the Soviet Union after the Second World War he wrote:

"We must not forget that in those years of atrocious persecution of the Jewish people, Soviet Russia has been the only great nation who has saved hundreds of thousands of Jewish lives. The enterprise to settle 30,000 Jewish war orphans in Birobidjan and secure for them in this way a satisfying and happy future is new proof for the humane attitude of Russia towards our Jewish people. In helping this cause we will contribute in a very effective way to the salvation of the remnants of European Jewry."

In the pivotal years between the end of the war and his death in 1955, Einstein was outspoken about the Jewish state project. Invited to testify before the Anglo-American Committee of Inquiry on Palestine in Washington, D.C., in January 1946, Einstein answered unequivocally when asked about the possible State of Israel versus a cultural homeland: "I have never been in favor of a state."

In March 1947, I.Z. David, a member of the Irgun terrorist group led by Menachem Begin, sent him a questionnaire to which he responded sharply and clearly:

Question: What is your opinion about the establishment of a free National Jewish Palestine?

Einstein: Jewish National Home? Yes. Jewish National Palestine? No. I favor a free, bi-national Palestine at a later date after agreement with the Arabs.

Question: Opinion about partition of Palestine and Chaim Weizmann's proposals re partition?

Einstein: I am against partition.

On the question of British and American imperialism, Einstein had no illusions as London handed over to Washington:

"It seems to me that our beloved Americans are now patterning their foreign policy on the model of the Germans, since they appear to have inherited the latter's inflatedness and arrogance. Apparently, they also want to take on the role England has played up to now. They refuse to learn from each other; and learn little even from their own harsh experience. What has been implanted into the heads from early youth is rooted more firmly than experience and reasoning. The English are yet another good example of this. Their old-fashioned methods of suppressing the masses by using indigenous unscrupulous elements from the economic upper class will soon cost them their whole empire, but they are incapable to bring themselves to change their methods; no matter whether it's the Tories or the Socialists. With the Germans, it was exactly the same. All of this would be good and well, except for the fact that it's so sad for the better elements and the oppressed... (Letter to Hans Mühsam)

As for the political ancestors of the current Netanyahu government, Einstein tore into them and their political parties, particularly in *The New York Times*. When Menachem Begin came to New York in late 1948, Einstein, Hannah Arendt, and other Jewish figures in the United States published a letter denouncing his visit and the organization he led calling it "a political party very close in its organization, methods, political philosophy and social appeal to the Nazi and fascist parties." One example they cited was the massacre of 240 men, women, and children in the Palestinian village of Deir Yassin.

Einstein would repeat this accusation until his death in 1955: "These people are Nazis in their thoughts and actions." Anyone who says this today in the mainstream media is immediately labeled an anti-Semite and banned from the same media.

It is common knowledge that when Chaim Weizmann died in 1952 the Prime Minister of Israel offered the presidency of Israel to Albert Einstein. Less well known, however, is the reason Einstein gave for this refusal: "I would have to say to the Israeli people things they would not like to hear." Even less well-known is Ben Gurion's statement: "Tell me what to do if he says yes! I've had to offer him the post because it was impossible not to, but if he accepts we are in for trouble."

Hundreds, if not thousands, of people are being accused of anti-Semitism or fired from their jobs because they dare to criticize the State of Israel, call it an apartheid state, and denounce the genocide of the Palestinians. May they rest assured: they are in good company, because if Einstein were alive today, he would be in the front lines demonstrating with them.

All quotes are from *Einstein on Israel and Zionism*, New Enriched Edition by Fred Jerome.

Robin Philpot is a graduate of the University of Toronto and founder of Baraka Books in Montreal. He is the author of *A People's History of Quebec*, with Jacques Lacoursière (2009) and *Rwanda and the New Scramble For Africa: From Tragedy to Useful Imperial Fiction* (2013), among other works. Robin can be reached at philpotrobin@gmail.com.

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46. Wanted Poster of the Palestine Police offering rewards for the capture of Irgun Z'vai Leumi terrorists: 1. Menachem Begin; 2. Arieh Ben Eliezer; 3. Leib Boyko; 4. Reuben Franco; and 5. Marek Kahane.

Wanted poster in the late 1940s which Begin is featured because of his involvement in terrorist acts. [Source: greenolive.com]

“We warned you,” Muslim Voters Tell Kamala Harris After She Goes Down in Flames

ARUN GUPTA

As return comes in from the 2024 election, it looks like two of the states in Kamala Harris’s “Blue Wall” fell to Donald Trump because she [loudly supported](#) Israel’s genocide of Gaza for months.

In Michigan, Harris lost by 81,000 votes while in Wisconsin Trump slipped by with barely 30,000 votes. In 2020, one report calculated there were [206,000 registered Muslim voters](#) in Michigan. The Muslim-American community is a rapidly growing population, and the number of registered Muslim voters in Michigan in 2024 is probably closer to 250,000.

In Dearborn, Michigan, the largest Arab majority U.S. city with a population of 110,000 residents, [Joe Biden hauled in](#) 74 percent of the vote in 2020, while Trump limped in with 24 percent. This time around [Trump triumphed](#) with 42 percent of the vote to only 36 percent for Harris and another 18 percent for Jill Stein. [Al Jazeera estimates](#) that Dearborn alone accounted for a 20,000-vote swing, or one quarter of Trump’s margin in the state.

Given the size of the Arab- and Muslim-American population in Michigan, it appears they tipped the race to Trump singlehandedly. But other Democratic quarters also abandoned Harris angered at her blank check for Israel. This includes Gen Z voters who were in the forefront of the pro-Palestine movement, left-wing activists, Black voters who see a direct parallel between Israel’s extermination of Gaza and the Jim Crow South and South African apartheid, and any voter outraged by the fact Washington has enabled the worst genocide of this century.

These are small and scattered groups that would require a lot of canvassing and polling to track, but one clue of the impact of Gaza is that voters aged 18-29 barely went for [Harris by 54-43 over Trump](#). This is in sharp contrast to 2020 in which Biden netted at least 126,000 votes or more from the same age group in each of four swing states. Youth gave Biden a big push that edged him past Trump in Arizona, Georgia, Michigan, and Pennsylvania.

Young people are affected more by protests than older voters since they are likelier to be in the streets and less affected by conservative effects from careers and home ownership. In 2020, young voters came out in force to vote against Trump in response to his violent actions against the massive George Floyd protests. This time youth abandoned Biden and Harris after they spent a year aiding Israel’s genocide in every way possible—militarily, financially, politically, diplomatically, morally, and ideologically.

Compared to Michigan, there are far fewer Muslim voters in Wisconsin, [perhaps 25,000 to 30,000](#), but Trump is currently on top by a mere 29,367 votes. That also happens to be almost the exact same number of people who picked Jill Stein or Robert Kennedy in Wisconsin, [29,944 votes](#). Again, given all the other groups angered at the Democrats, it is likely that over Israel’s wars alone Harris lost Wisconsin.

Pennsylvania was the last state in Harris’s firewall, which went to Trump by 138,000 votes. Here the impact of Muslim and Arab voters on the election is unclear. In 2020 there were 167,000 Muslim voters in the state. Given the Muslim voting population had increased by 26 percent in the four years before 2020, there may have been closer to 200,000 eligible Muslim voters in Pennsylvania in 2024.

It is not yet known how they voted, but the Pennsylvania Council on American-Islamic Relations [issued a voter guide](#) that featured Jill Stein in the center of its cover. It described her opposition to arms for Israel, support for the Boycott, Divestment, and Sanctions movement, and denouncing Israel as genocidal. The guide also included the Libertarian Party candidate Chase Oliver and his position of “non-interventionism” and ending all foreign aid to Israel and Ukraine. Stein and Oliver notched almost the same exact vote total, about 33,000 each.

There is another significant factor that dragged down Harris over her support for Israel. Trump had a field day slamming Harris for being a warmonger on Israel and Ukraine. His surrogates like Tulsi Gabbard and RFK, Jr., warned supporters that Harris was causing chaos, barreling towards World War 3, and even risking nuclear war. Tucker Carlson and Trump mocked her alliance with Dick and Liz Cheney, pointing to the disastrous Iraq War that continues to destabilize the region.

Harris’s neocon foreign policy enabled Trump to don the mantle of peace and stability. There isn’t polling that indicates how much of an impact this had. But given how much Trump’s campaign pounded Harris over it looks like they figured out it was repelling plenty of voters from Harris and attracting them to Trump.

Ironically the Democrats are more ideological than Trump, MAGA, or the GOP. Israel is serving U.S. interests in re-ordering the Middle East violently and trying to topple Iran’s government. Harris was so committed to American Empire she was willing to lose the election. She was more committed to it than stopping a fascist from ending democracy and making women second-class citizens.

But in the end, she crumbled. Two days before the election Harris went to Michigan and [finally said](#), “I will do everything in my power to end the war in Gaza.” It was a victory for the Palestine solidarity movement and a desperate [Hail Mary play](#) for Harris. She could have said it two or three months ago. She could have let a Palestinian deliver a toned-down speech at the DNC like they pleaded to. Nope, she kept dog-whistling for genocide by saying “I support Israel’s right to defend itself.”

Politicians are masters of talking out of both sides of their mouths. It would have been easy to signal to Palestinian- and Muslim-Americans that she supported their cry for an end to the war while also winking at her wealthy Zionist backers and foreign policy establishment that she had their back.

Of course, no one should ever trust a politician to do what they say they’re going to do, except for maybe Bernie Sanders. But postmodern politics is about managing spectacle, making everyone think you’re on their side. Obama did it. Harris couldn’t.

But Trump did. That is why he won. Again.

Arun Gupta is an investigative reporter, French-trained chef, and author of the forthcoming Apocalypse Chow: A junk-food loving chef’s guide to taste. (The New Press)

This article first appeared in Arun’s Substack [Life, the Universe, and Most Things](#) on November 8, 2024.

Biden Going Out with a Bang

MICHAEL MOORE

Dear Joe,

What have you been doing? I saw you went to the rainforest. That looked cool. I loved how at the end you just turned away and walked into the jungle as if never to be seen again. All Presidencies should end this way.

A little over a month ago, [I sent you a nice letter](#) with some suggestions for how you could use the rest of your time as President of the United States of America. Things like canceling student debt once and for all, closing Guantanamo, freeing Cuba, freeing Leonard Peltier, pardoning Snowden, and doing other good deeds. Instead of doing any of these, you have done none of them.

In fact, if I'm reading the news right, you're going in the opposite direction. My suggestions were all about cementing your status as a "Great President"—about shaping your legacy, making you an unforgettable figure in the pantheon of all 44 white men who've presided over this country before you (and also your former boss). You on the other hand seem to be trying to cement your legacy as a warmonger—doubling down on some of your worst mistakes and worst impulses.

So, I'll ask again, what are you doing?

Donald Trump just won the election. In two months, you'll hand him the keys to the White House and the pin number for the alarm system. And you will be out of time.

Instead of using your precious little time left to do something to help the American people, your first action after Trump won was to fast-track the delivery of [over \\$6 billion in weapons](#) to Ukraine. Then, you called up Zelensky and gave him the green light [to start firing long-range ballistic missiles](#) into a country with a massive amount of nuclear weapons, Russia. Then, as if that weren't enough carnage for one week, you [authorized the use of antipersonnel land mines in Russia](#).

Land mines, Joe? Seriously? *This* is your legacy? *This* is how you want to go out? In a blaze of horror? Like, if Joe's gotta go, we all gotta go with him... right into World War III?

Joe—America has spent well over a billion dollars removing landmines from places like Iraq, Afghanistan, Vietnam, Laos, and Cambodia (you know, the places we invade and then leave our landmines behind). Vietnam was 50 years ago, Joe. And kids today in southeast Asia are still getting their arms blown off by our landmines. That's your legacy, Joe. This is what you're doing.

This week, [19 brave Democrats rose in the Senate](#) and voted in favor of halting a shipment of weapons to Israel. And what did the Biden White House do? [You lobbied against these Democratic Senators](#). You were scared that others would join them, pleading with Schumer and the others to vote them down, to shut them up, to keep arming this slaughter in Gaza and the West Bank and Lebanon. So, you decided to

slander this group of Senators from your own party. You said that by halting these armaments to Israel, these Democrats were on the side of Hamas.

Also, this week, at the United Nations, 14 of the 15 members of the Security Council voted in favor of an immediate ceasefire in Gaza. Fourteen of Fifteen, Joe. And your administration cast that 15th lone vote to veto a chance for peace. [America once again single-handedly blocked the ceasefire](#). The only country speaking out in favor of more death and destruction was the one you and I are citizens of. This is your legacy, Joe?

The week ended with the International Criminal Court in the Hague, the most important criminal court prosecuting war crimes in the world, [issuing an actual arrest warrant for Benjamin Netanyahu](#). Democracies throughout the world—including Canada—announced that they would abide by the ICC warrant and take Netanyahu into custody should he ever set foot on their soil. And [your White House's response was to reject the warrants](#) and condemn the court for issuing them? For pursuing justice? Is this your legacy, Joe?

What about us, Joe? What about America? You have two months left in office. What are you going to do with this time? Maybe you should stop arming foreign wars and leave that for the next guy. Maybe instead, you should focus on things that matter to Americans.

So once again, Joe, I am calling on you to use your power of the pen—and your complete immunity!—to make some real and powerful change.

How about starting with a no-brainer? The equal rights amendment for women.

You have the power to order the E.R.A. to be officially published in the United States Constitution. You've had nearly 4 years to do this. It was ratified by the required number of states and it should be published as the 28th Amendment to the Constitution. Women, who make up 51% of the American population—the majority—should finally be recognized as equal citizens and equal human beings, endowed by their creator with certain unalienable rights, just as they are in almost every single other Western Democracy.

A massive coalition of groups, all across America have come together this week-end asking millions of Americans to email and call the White House every day for the next two months, calling on you, Joe Biden, to finally make the Equal Rights Amendment the law of the land.

You have the power to do this, Joe. You have the power to make this your legacy.

So, Joe, I'm really telling you for the last time: Just do it.

Michael Francis Moore is an American film director, producer, screenwriter, and author.

This article first appeared on Michael Moore's [Substack](#) on November 23, 2024.

It Takes a Village

RAY PETERSEN

The zebra we saw in the cornfield on our drive out to Osage, Iowa was an early sign that we were soon to see something unusual and unexpected. And even though what we found in Osage was not as dramatic, it has left a more lasting impression.

There was a different energy in Osage as if this community shared the best of our past simultaneously with the promise of the future. When we arrived, Osage for over a generation had been using energy efficiency as a means of promoting the well-being of the community. Just a few months earlier the country had been engaged in Desert Storm, a war fought over oil, not the first nor the last.

What was so different about the energy in the community of Osage? It found ways to not need foreign oil.

What was the technological breakthrough that made this possible? Better insulation and windows for their homes; more efficient and healthier lighting; low-flow shower heads; weatherstripping; and a new culture that valued “living more comfortably at lower cost”—the Osage definition of energy efficiency. This definition came from the director of Osage’s Municipal Electric System, Wes Birdsall, to counter the 1970s oil company advertising that depicted energy conservation as “freezing to death in the dark.”

This was no easy task, as Birdsall related to me in person. It took a few years to overcome that image of deprivation and a new term of energy efficiency, as well as some innovative counter-information in the monthly utility bill envelopes.

“We got an infrared camera and took pictures of people’s homes in the evening when their house lights were out. Many homes were bathed in a white glow. This was a heating loss from the poor windows and door insulations,” Birdsall said. He had the photos mailed to the municipal utility customers, and after a while “people started to come in and ask, ‘What can we do about this?’ I knew we had turned a corner when that started happening.”

Our kids were playing on a public playground while I was interviewing Wes, enjoying the fruits of a community that had lower taxes and utility rates because of their simple, straightforward efforts to “live more comfortably at a lower cost.” A community of 3500 people at the peak of their efficiency efforts was able to save \$1.1 million per year. When Wes told me this, I did the math quickly in my head for Oswego County, New York, where we lived at the time. The county population was roughly 30 times that of Osage in the early ‘90s. What could we do with an extra 33 million dollars at our disposal while at the same time living better?

I thanked Wes, and my wife and I got all five kids loaded into the station wagon, with the two of our youngest strapped into car seats, pulling a small trailer with camping gear, and we headed north to our next energy efficiency community, Lester Prairie, Minnesota. The innovator in Lester Prairie was a public-school science teacher and the mayor, Eric Ingvall. What kind of Middle American community of

1100 people can afford to have a municipal pool and community center? One that has an energy efficiency program guided by a team of public-minded citizens, including the owner of a non-franchise hardware store stocking the latest in Energy Star products. It is a community that, during the buildup to the Gulf War, initiated a Ride Share program that proved transportation costs could be cut to the point where no foreign oil would be needed there. It is the community with a public-school science teacher as mayor who was so well respected that the governor established an Eric Ingvall Day to celebrate those achievements. It is a community where the mayor’s family welcomes a family of strangers and makes them feel so comfortable their five children drift off to sleep in their living room as their parents get acquainted with the First Family of the village.

One more distinction needs to be made in describing Lester Prairie. A few miles from town, there is a park featuring a long boardwalk that winds visitors through a marsh. This walk so thoroughly immerses the hiker into nature that it engages all the senses in the experience, making the native pilot black snake we encountered moving across the planks more of a neighbor than an intruder because we were on his turf, in his domain.

There were more stops on this journey seeking glimpses of energy-efficient USA, including Cortez, Colorado, where the program intended to see how many new jobs could be created, and Olympia, Washington, where Mike Grady (Chief Growth Management Planner for the Washington State Energy Office and Department of Community Development) walked me through a state-funded energy efficiency program that had already produced 20 full-time jobs and paid back its starter grant on the state college campus in Ellensburg. The results had proved so promising that they were contemplating duplicating it with a water efficiency program, also to create new jobs.

New York State lacked the supportive regulatory framework that had enabled Washington State’s progress and also the kind of municipal utility operation that had made the Osage, Iowa program so successful. However, that did not discourage the Town of Fenner from establishing one of the largest wind farms in the state in Madison County, a 30-megawatt facility providing enough clean, renewable power for 7800 homes.

There is a Free Center at the wind farm in Fenner that provides information on other forms of renewable energy available to communities, such as another facility in the town that was using the gas from solid waste to provide additional electricity to the community. While on a tour bus on its way to the Free Center, I had the opportunity to talk with Town Supervisor Russ Carey about the benefits of their renewable energy facilities. He pointed out that with the savings from the wind farm contract they were able to purchase the best snow removal equipment for the highway department so their hilly roads in Madison County would be safer and maintained more inexpensively, while simultaneously cutting taxes.

Like the Washington State model, this is an excellent example of the concept of spillover, where progress in one area of environmental policy creates momentum for change in other areas. It is what is known as transformational politics, as the energy of citizen engagement not only causes changes in technology and processes but also in cultural values.

The bottom line is that by engaging in the activity of taking charge of their own communities' energy destiny, each individual involved has the opportunity to increase their sense of efficacy—the feeling that their participation will matter. Participants may feel this is more empowering than voting and essential, though it occurs much less frequently and with limited options for voter choice. Because the impact is felt in real terms, it generates more than just clean, renewable, resilient energy; it creates democratic energy.

Ray Petersen is an emeritus Professor of Political Science and History at Jefferson Community College – SUNY. He wrote about community energy policy as part of his research from a sabbatical leave in the early 1990s and later included some more current examples of community energy policy that he feels will be needed more than ever given the recent election results.

“There is no power for change greater than a community discovering what it cares about.”

- Margaret J. Wheatley

Ukraine and US Imperialist Strategy

GARY OLSON

In mid-November, Biden—or, given his diminished mental capacity, whoever is now in charge—authorized the Kyiv regime to launch Lockheed Martin-produced Army Tactical Missile Systems or ATACMS to hit targets 190 miles inside Russia. In response, an ICBM was fired in wartime for the first time when the Oreshnik (“Hazelnut Tree”), an intermediate-range, nuclear-capable missile, took only 5 minutes to hit Dnipro, Ukraine. The Kremlin gave Washington a 30-minute warning before the launch. Putin called the US/ NATO bluff, and he promised that future retaliation could target “decision-making centers” in Kyiv.

This new Russian weapon can reach Warsaw in 1 minute 1 second, Berlin in 2 minutes 55 seconds, and London in 6 minutes 56 seconds. Europe has no defense system that can intercept it. Putin said recently that when several Oreshniks are used simultaneously, “the resulting impact is comparable in power to that of a nuclear weapon.” Despite Russian warnings about escalating the conflict, the US continues to blow past all red lines and on November 23 and 25, the Kiev regime fired a dozen more ATACMS into Russian territory.

Here it’s imperative to briefly recall how the US imperialist strategy toward Russia got us into this dire situation. Contrary to the official narrative, the war in Ukraine did not begin with an “unprovoked” Russian invasion of Ukraine on February 27, 2022. Rather, as Jeffrey Sachs of Columbia University wrote, “In fact, the war was provoked by the United States in ways that leading US diplomats had anticipated for decades leading up to the war, which means that the war could have been avoided and should be stopped through negotiations.” (Common Dreams, 5/23/23). Virtually all policy experts and Russian leaders warned that NATO expansion was, in the words of CIA Director William Burns, the “brightest of all red lines for the Russian elites (not just Putin) of whom would see it as a direct challenge to Russian interests.” George Kennan, architect of U.S. containment policy, called it “a tragic mistake.”

Despite these warnings, at the June 2008 Bucharest Summit, NATO leaders pronounced that “Ukraine will become a NATO member,” and at the Brussels meeting on June 14, 2021, NATO reiterated that “Ukraine will be a member of NATO.” The Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov countered, “The key to everything is that NATO will not expand eastward.” In truth, given all the US/NATO arms and military training flowing to the Kyiv regime, it’s apparent that Ukraine was already a de facto NATO member.

Anyone with a scintilla of working brain matter understood that no government in Moscow would tolerate the decision to bring Ukraine into NATO. Russia viewed NATO expansion on its border as an existential threat and legitimately feared that the US, under the guise of NATO, would place missiles 317 miles or 5 minutes flying time from decapitating the Kremlin. What would Washington’s response be if Russia or China struck a “defensive” alliance with Canada or Mexico and began placing missiles on the U.S. border? Or think of the Monroe Doctrine.

In short, the war hawk neocons who prevail in Washington were fully aware of the above but wanted to provoke a proxy war to be fought to the last Ukrainian. They expected the conflict would depower Russia — and perhaps even precipitate a regime change — so the US could move on to the Strait of Taiwan and a likely confrontation with China, the primary peer challenger to US global domination.

Since 2002, the US has squandered \$174 billion of aid and military assistance on Ukraine, money that's desperately needed for addressing the cost of living, housing, education, and health care for the working class here at home. Further, there have been more than half a million Ukrainians and Russians killed on the battlefield in a war that could have been avoided had the US given up the idea of Ukraine joining NATO.

According to the AP (11/29/2024), as many as 200,000 soldiers may have deserted from the Ukrainian army. In response, Blinken is pressuring Ukraine to lower the conscription age to 18 which could add 350,000 in meat for the grinder. I sense that Blinken & Co. are attempting to prolong the war as long as possible so that when the inevitable defeat does occur, we will hear the refrain, "Trump lost Ukraine."

Despite all the official disinformation and propaganda on behalf of the war, a majority of Ukrainians no longer support it (Gallup, 19 November 2024), and Americans now oppose more military aid for Ukraine. In our recent presidential election, voters registered a strong mandate to end the "endless wars". Here, where I reside in Pennsylvania, a majority believe the US is "too involved" in foreign affairs. (CATO/YouGov/9/9/24). Over the past three years, Trump has promised to end the war in Ukraine, and during his debate with Kamala Harris, he said, "I want this war to stop." In his November 5 victory speech, Trump declared, "I'm not going to start wars, I'm going to end them." We'll soon see if the unpredictable and erratic Trump adheres to his promise. Given Deep State opposition and some of Trump's appointees, I'm not optimistic.

In the meantime, no sane person can wish the current situation to unfold into a global thermonuclear exchange and the annihilation of the earth's people. I am old enough to recall how the US responded when Russia attempted to put missiles in Cuba, and I suspect we are now closer to World War III than we were during those 13 fateful days in October 1962.

Gary Olson is Professor Emeritus of Political Science at Moravian University in Bethlehem, PA; his books include U.S. Foreign Policy and the Third World Peasant (1974), The Other Europe (1977), How the World Works (1981) and Empathy Imperiled: Capitalism, Culture and the Brain (2013).

Source: Gary Olson's Substack on 2 Dec. 2024: <https://substack.com/home/post/p-152450517>

Love My Black Job

RAYMOND NAT TURNER

Love my Black Job —
Black Student Union Job!
Hired at L.A. City College
As "The Peoples Poet!"

Love my Black Job — opening
For Baldwin on the football field
Seven or eight thousand pairs of
Ears on loan!

Love my Black Job — had a lil
Following — but learned, in time, what I
Didn't know was enough to get People
Killed.

Love my Black Job — ensconced in Jazz
Cats' world of 'shedding' as breathing;
Hooked on their carrot-celery juice, clean
Vegetarian diets ...

Love my Black Job — heard an Angel
From Bombingham — and caught a case of
German materialism — got
Dialectical and historical 'bout things Black ...

Love my Black Job — an African-American
Employee of IBM (Italian Business Men) —
Associate of a prominent NY crime family
Promoted me: "The Town Crier!"

Love my Black Job — 104 year-old Jewish
Woman taught me meditation in her Manhattan
Haunts — bakery/coffee shop — where she
Posted up, entourage in tow, and held court daily

Love my Black Job — at the Schomburg — Standing
On Langston's ashes; Getting one last photo with
Amiri — the other Jersey Boy I followed fan-boyishly
Coast to coast!

(continued on next page)

Love my Black Job—2016 tenure—rebutting Boss Tweet’s
Blitzkrieg! MAGAt team 140-character-fecal explosions—all
Caps! Tortured my friends into fetal positions—or sent them
Scurrying to put passports in order ...

Love my Black Job—when Duopoly singers show up teaching
Dead end \$campaign/\$election songs; And stiff, wooden, 2/4
Dances they call ‘Democracy’—sans Socialist, Communist,
Labor parties—Sidelined and silenced ...like the lambs ...

Love my Black Job—Last Days of Pompeio; low Barr
Bible beatdowns. Flash-bang, baton, teargas punctuated!
Love my Black Job doing what Douglass said do—to
Covert clown/acrobats dangling from a dictator’s warhead!

Love my Black Job—defeat Boss Tweet elite—MAGAt
Budapest biting the body politic! M-pox poisoned Gremlin
Grifter. Asset whose addled brain’s eaten away by wet dreams:
Playing Pinochet—1st 100 Daze—of Day One ...

*Former forklift driver/warehouse worker/janitor, Raymond Nat Turner is a NYC poet; BAR’s
Poet-in-Residence; and founder/co-leader of the jazz-poetry ensemble UpSurge!NYC. [Read
other articles by Raymond Nat](#), or [visit Raymond Nat’s website](#).*

Notes From the Editor (continued from inside front cover)

along.” In Philadelphia, where over 50 percent of Black people are living in poverty, the Black mayor confidently predicted that 680,000 votes would be cast for Kamala Harris. She received 547,000.

Nationwide, some half of those of eligible voting age abstained from the process. Here I think that the astute political analyst Garland Nixon is on to something when he suggests that pollsters not only include “likely” voters but also “unlikely” ones. I’d wager that we’d find tens of millions of people who’ve given up on politics because they know it has nothing to offer them. I mention this because these data would not only honestly flesh out the national narrative but highlight the grievances of a segment of the population that could potentially alter the country’s future.

Those pulling the puppet strings of our duopoly fear rule by the people and because their first allegiance is to maintaining the capitalist system—the ultimate cause of our crisis—they have no answers, only more misdirection. After the tone-deaf, reality-denying Democrats finish their ritualistic circular firing squad, the DNC will begin looking to 2028. Perhaps this time they’ll settle on a Gavin Newsom or a Josh Shapiro. We can hope so because that will prefigure the final death knell of the Democratic Party.

We are entering an immensely dangerous period with the moral monsters of late-stage capitalism thrashing about in our midst. But this is also a time of great opportunity to begin creating a mass working-class party. We can’t squander the chance.

(1) *Genociders must be punished.*

If you vote for them, you are telling them that they can get away with anything including the greatest of all crimes against humanity and in the case of Gaza a genocide against one of the most vulnerable people on the planet. If we can’t even electorally or symbolically send them a message that Thou Shall Not Commit Genocide and expect our votes, then we guarantee their invincibility and nothing else matters. The genociders will be laughing at us to the bank.

(2) *A political system that consistently produces no choice other than genocide (both candidates) is neither democratic nor worth fighting for or keeping.*

It’s about time to oppose it root and branch before it devours us all and makes the planet unlivable too in service to capitalism and militarism.

(3) *A people who do not rise to end their government’s enabling of a live-streaming, by now more-than-450-day-long genocide, does not deserve to keep their privileges at home nor ask others who oppose genocide to please vote for the Party committing genocide to keep their privileges at home.*

The keep-privileges-at-home-tolerate-genocide-abroad posture is a morally depraved and indefensible position. It’s the utter self-centeredness of a people, who jump into action to save their privileges, all the while tolerating their complicity in terror and genocide abroad.

The (neo)liberals’ anguish and deep depression in reaction to Kamala Harris’s loss to Donald Trump’s victory points to a deep-seated problem with contemporary liberalism, namely its truncated sense of human empathy, one that is limited at worse to the pain and suffering of one’s immediate circle of family and friends and at best to that of certain segments of one’s society. An expansive sense of empathy, on the other hand, would break through any artificial boundaries that aim to enclose that precious human

ability to empathize with the suffering of others. If modern liberalism had nurtured such a universal sense, the liberals would have exhibited a deep depression and anguish over their favorite candidate's genocide in Gaza. But, if liberalism had indeed nurtured a universal sense of empathy, our capitalist overlords would have long ago jettisoned it for another ideology with an appropriately hyper-individualistic core.

The Democratic Party could have made an unforgettable history of its own, trumping Trump's, and restore some sense of human decency by cutting off the US military aid to Israel and ending the Gaza genocide. But alas!

A news flash from a sane(r) world: The European Union sanctions US and Israeli officials, military figures, and US corporations for supplying deadly weapons to apartheid Israel following its genocide in Palestine.

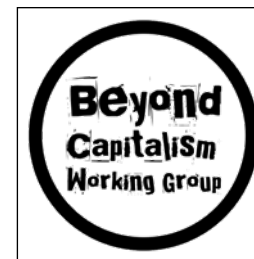
Those who support the US/Israeli Killing Machine in Gaza are reactionaries. Those who think this Killing Machine can defeat all resistance to its brutality don't know much about history. Those who have chosen to be silent or refuse to stand in solidarity with Palestinians have lost their humanity.

Israel is intensifying its ethnic cleansing in the West Bank while the world's attention is focused on Gaza and Lebanon. There are no surprises here if you know what Zionism is. The dominant form of Zionism is a racist settler colonial movement. The elimination of the natives is central to settler colonialism in general. It can resort to either ethnic cleansing, genocide, or both to accomplish its objective. An apartheid system follows logically when settlers are unable to fully eradicate the natives. Israel has found this post-October 7, 2023, genocidal moment to be as good as any in its history to further advance its settler colonial project. As in the past with the British empire, Israel depends on the full backing of Euro-American imperialism and its subordinated and reactionary Arab allies in West Asia. But, this time, Israel may be digging its own grave, given its live-streaming brutality. Critical questions to ponder are, 'How much longer will North Americans tolerate a corrupted US political system with two genocidal political parties?', 'How much longer will they let the mainstream media and politicians manipulate them to submit to the rule of the few at home and the slaughter of the many abroad masked by the deceptive rhetoric of a "rules-based international order"?' It remains to be seen.

"Israel now holds the world records for the murder of journalists, of aid workers, of UN officials, and of healthcare workers" (Craig Mokhiber, ex-director of the NY Office of the UN High Commissioner for Human Rights) with full Western political/economic/military/media support.

Join us via Zoom 7:00–9:00 PM on Fridays
for political discussions and Thursdays to watch
and discuss significant films and politics.

(Zoom link moravian.zoom.us/j/8075321907)



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